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● GROUND REPORT

AIADMK leader EPS kicks off election campaign with scathing attack on DMK

THE BATTLE BEGINS. Palaniswami proclaims AIADMK-led NDA alliance will secure 200-plus seats, govern in the interests of the people

Rohan Das
Chennai

With iconic songs of MGR and Jayalithaa blaring from speakers and the party symbol dominating the landscape, AIADMK supremo Edappadi Palaniswami kicked off his election campaign in Chennai on Wednesday.

Unlike the usual sprawling fields, large stages and a string of party bigwigs, Palaniswami chose a narrow market road in Mylapore, a constituency in Chennai with a sizeable population of upper caste voters.

HUGE TURNOUT

The gathering, cutting across the young and old, witnessed a huge presence of women, with school children enamoured by the spectacle. The crowd roared in affirmation to every set of attack made by Palaniswami on the DMK

regime. The allegations were broad, ranging from the State's law and order, infrastructure issues in Chennai and the rising prices of consumables such as vegetables and cooking oil. "The DMK government has perfected only three things – collection, commission and corruption," he said.

SHAKY ALLIANCE

Attacks were also levelled against the DMK's allegedly shaky alliance as the AIADMK leader noted that the party is "treating its partners like slaves".

Palaniswami proclaimed that the AIADMK-led NDA alliance will secure 200-plus seats, and bring back a government that works for the people, not one that survives on deception, corruption and false promises. He noted that the Mylapore constituency had been allotted to the BJP.



CAMPAIGN TRAIL. AIADMK General Secretary Edappadi Palaniswami at his first election rally in Chennai on Wednesday BUJO GHOSH

While he did not name the candidate contesting the seat, BJP leader and former Governor of Telangana Tamilisai Soundararajan accompanied him in the roadshow in Mylapore.

SLEW OF FREEBIES

Though the attacks on the

DMK came sharp, he also stressed on his poll pitch, which included a host of freebies. Given the current situation, his promise of

LPG cylinders got him the loudest response, with a middle-aged woman exclaiming that gas cylinders now cost over ₹1,000.

● STATE OF PLAY: PUDUCHERRY

Is early NDA consolidation putting INDIA Bloc on the back foot?

Our Bureau
Chennai

With less than three weeks to go for the polls on April 9, the race for Puducherry is just taking shape after weeks of infighting in the INDIA Bloc even as the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) has managed to stitch together its unit faster.

With the clock ticking towards the deadline to file nominations, it took a high-level meeting between P Chidambaram and MK Stalin to salvage a fragile pact for the INDIA bloc. The Congress-DMK alliance entered the race on a shaky footing after prolonged wrangling over seat-sharing delayed preparations until the final days before the nominations closed.

After more than a week of tense negotiations, the Congress and the DMK eventually finalised a formula, under which the Congress will contest 16 seats and the DMK 14 in the 30-member Assembly. This brought back memories of the infighting between INDIA Bloc partners in the Bihar polls, where friendly fights between allies cost the alliance a number of seats, and mirrored the seat-

sharing conflict that has been on in Tamil Nadu for the 2026 polls.

However, the dialogue between Chidambaram and Stalin finally led to a broad arrangement, under which the DMK is contesting 14 seats, leaving 16 to the Congress. The DMK is also allotting one seat each to the Communist Party of India and the Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK).

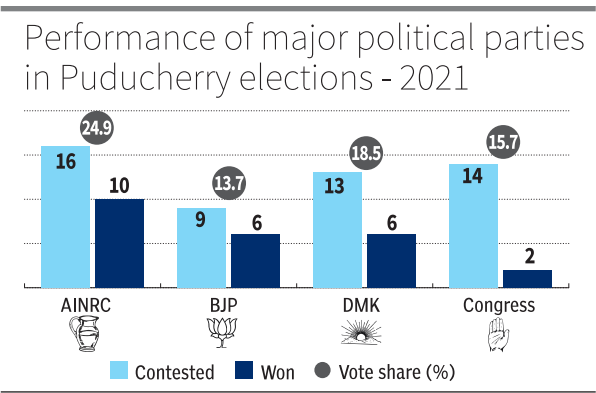
VCK 'INDEPENDENT'

However, unhappy with just one seat and without clarity on which seat that would be, VCK President Thol Thirumavalavan announced that his party would contest independently from Oussudu, Nettapakkam and Oulgaret.

While both parties laid claim to several key constituencies in this process, the leaders of the alliance assured at a press conference that the partnership was solid, and that differences would be ironed out by internal dialogue.

With Thursday being the last day for withdrawal of nominations, the final picture of contestants is set to become clearer, and the Union Territory can finally move on to campaign mode.

In contrast, the ruling



Source: Election Commission of India

NDA moved relatively faster to formalise its electoral understanding. The alliance, led by Chief Minister N Rangasamy of the All India NR Congress (AINRC), finalised its pact with the Bharatiya Janata Party, while allocating two seats each to the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) and the Latchiya Jananayaga Katchi (LJK).

The agreement helped stabilise the alliance after initial disagreements, and allowed the NDA to move quickly into campaign mode.

Rangasamy, who has remained a central political figure in Puducherry politics, is expected to anchor the NDA campaign with emphasis on administrative continuity,

development and stronger alignment with the Centre, themes the ruling alliance hopes will resonate with the voters.

Adding a fresh variable to the contest is the entry of actor-turned-politician Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), which has chosen to contest all 30 seats.

While analysts believe the party is unlikely to emerge as a dominant force in its debut election, its presence is expected to influence outcomes in tight contests by splitting votes, particularly among younger voters and in urban constituencies. This multi-cornered configuration, with both major alliances facing internal adjust-

ments, has set the stage for a competitive and unpredictable electoral cycle.

KEY ISSUES

Local concerns remain central to voter sentiment across the Union Territory. Issues such as infrastructure disparities, electricity tariffs, tourism-related pressures and concerns over law and order are emerging as recurring themes in campaign discourse.

At the same time, industrial growth and the long-standing demand for statehood continue to feature prominently in the political messaging. Analysts suggest the contest may hinge less on broad ideological narratives and more on alliance discipline, candidate selection and constituency-level dynamics. In tightly contested seats, marginal vote shifts triggered by smaller parties or local grievances could determine the outcome.

Political analyst Ramu Manivannan noted that the BJP-AINRC combine holds a "thin edge" in the fight, supported by voter expectations around Central assistance and Statehood.

He added that Vijay's entry had introduced unpredictability, but may not con-

vert into significant electoral gains.

ANTI-INCUMBENCY

At the ground level, residents point to limited anti-incumbency against Rangasamy, though internal dissatisfaction within party ranks persists. Infrastructure has emerged as a central issue.

Voters like small-scale industrialist Raghavan in Villanor highlighted stark disparities in development within Puducherry, particularly between the well-maintained White Town area and other parts of the city, underscoring demands for more equitable urban planning.

With several constituencies expected to witness tight contests and some ministers facing strong challenges, the April 9 election is likely to hinge on local dynamics, alliance cohesion and marginal vote shifts.

For now, the defining feature of the campaign remains the contrast in momentum — the NDA that consolidated early versus the INDIA bloc that took longer to settle internal disputes, setting up a race where timing, cohesion and ground mobilisation could prove decisive.

QUICKLY.

AIADMK unveils constituency-wise allocation for allies

Chennai: The All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) on Wednesday released the full constituency-wise allocation for the National Democratic Alliance. The party, which is leading the alliance, has retained most of the seats, including Edappadi and Natham, where it won in 2021. Of the 234 Assembly constituencies, the AIADMK will contest in 169 seats, leaving 65 constituencies to the seven alliance partners, including the BJP. In Chennai, one seat (Mylapore) has been allotted to the BJP; two (Saidapet and Poonamallee) for the Amma Makal Munnetra Kazhagam, and one (Pallavaram) for the Indhiya Jananayaka Katchi.



Sources said the BJP was hoping that it would also get T Nagar, but that did not happen. The national party will also contest in Coimbatore (North) and Madurai (South). Seat allocation is based on proclaimed strength and potential vote share. It is logical for the BJP to get one in Chennai, said a source. Interestingly, Tirunelveli and Coimbatore South, from where Tamil Nadu BJP President Nainar Nagendran and Vanathi Srinivasan won in 2021 did not figure in the list of constituencies allotted to the BJP. Both may contest from other constituencies.

On Wednesday, AIADMK released its first list of 23 candidates, including 21 former ministers. It has renominated 16 sitting MLAs and fielded several senior leaders across key constituencies. Party General Secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami will seek re-election from his home constituency Edappadi, while Deputy General Secretary KP Munusamy has been nominated from Veppanahalli. Treasurer Dindigul C Srinivasan will contest from Dindigul. Among the prominent names are former Ministers Natham R Viswanathan (Natham), SP Velumani (Tondamuthur), P Thangamani (Kumarapalayam), D Jayakumar (Royapuram) and C Ve Shanmugam (Mylam), who have been fielded again. **OUR BUREAU**

Tennis legend Leander Paes joins BJP ahead of Bengal elections

Kolkata: Tennis legend Leander Paes stepped into active politics on Wednesday by joining the BJP just ahead of the Assembly elections in West Bengal. Paes met BJP National President Nitin Nabin in Kolkata.



Party State President Samik Bhattacharya was also present during the meeting. The meeting coincided with Nabin's two-day visit to the city, aimed at sharpening the party's election strategies. It is, however, not clear whether Paes would be fielded by the saffron party in the upcoming elections. Paes joining the BJP has marked a notable shift, given his earlier association with the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress. Notably, the saffron party released its second list of 111 candidates last week for the Assembly polls in Bengal. Earlier, the party had released its first list of 144 candidates. The BJP announced that Bharat Chhetri, a former Indian hockey team captain, would be contesting from the Kalimpong seat. The 294-member West Bengal Assembly will go to the polls in two phases on April 23 and 29. **OUR BUREAU**

‘We are set to create a new Kerala’

bl.interview

V Sajeew Kumar
Chitra Narayanan
Kochi

At a press conference in Kochi, senior Congress leader Ramesh Chennithala brushed aside questions on the lack of a chief ministerial face for the UDF.

He said the beauty of the UDF was that it had plenty of leaders unlike the LDF which had only one, and that the Congress party's high command would choose the CM. He shared his vision for the State in this exclusive interview.

Edited excerpts:

What are the big poll issues for the UDF?

The anti-incumbency of the government is definitely going to be favourable for us. Ten years is a long period, and the LDF government of Kerala has not performed.

The government has not taken any initiative to redress the grievances of the people.

On the contrary, people's problems have increased manifold. So, the people are seeking a change in the government. Price rise is also a big issue. No industry has come here. There is hardly any private investment in



The anti-incumbency of the government is definitely going to be favourable for us. Ten years is a long period, and the LDF government of Kerala has not performed

RAMESH CHENNITHALA
Senior Congress leader

Kerala, while other States are getting projects worth crores.

That is why lakhs of students from Kerala are going abroad. Political violence also takes place on the campuses by the SFI and others. So, people are fed up with that, and they are going abroad, seeking higher studies and jobs. Exodus of the young from Kerala is a big issue. When we come to power, we will give quality education of global standards.

Does the UDF have any industry friendly plans?

For the last five years, the UDF has been the prime opposition in the State, and you will notice that we have not initiated any strike or bandh because we want invest-



ment in the State government.

Have you chartered out any vision for industrial development?

We are primarily for industrial development. Our students should not go outside, and Kerala should not become an old-age State.

We have already become a silver economy like Japan, with more older people and fewer young people.

On the political front, the analysis seems to be that Christians' votes will be the deciding factor in the State elections. How are you addressing that?

Our stronghold has always been Christians and Muslims. We have the support of the Hindu community, too. This time also the same thing will continue.

Other than the anti-incumbency factor, what else do you think might favour the UDF?

Rahul Gandhi has declared five guarantees (free bus travel for women, ₹1,000 a month for college girls, welfare pensions of ₹3,000, health insurance and interest-free loans of up to ₹5 lakh for small businesses).

We are set to create a new Kerala.

As strikes fade and industries spring up, Rajeeve pitches a new narrative for Kerala

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

In a State once synonymous with disruptive strikes and frequent hartals, Kerala's industrial landscape is being recast as a stable zone under Industries Minister P Rajeeve, a young face in the Communist Party of India (Marxist), who is widely regarded as one of its rising political stars.

With labour unrest now far less visible than in earlier decades, Rajeeve has positioned himself as a key architect of Kerala's attempt to rebrand itself as an investor-friendly destination ahead of the 2026 Assembly elections.

A NEW IMAGE

Campaigning in his constituency of Kalamassery in Ernakulam district, widely regarded as the State's industrial nerve centre, Rajeeve told *businessline* that the Left Democratic Front (LDF) government's industrial push had helped Kerala shed, what he called, its "long-standing image of being an industry-unfriendly State. It was not an easy task. It was the result of our concerted efforts to put the State back on the developmental track." Before enter-



P Rajeeve, Minister for Law and Industries

ing the State Cabinet, Rajeeve built his political reputation in New Delhi as a member of the Rajya Sabha from 2009 to 2015, and earned recognition across party lines as one of the most active parliamentarians of his term. His performance drew unusual bipartisan appreciation, and when his tenure ended, leaders cutting across ideological divides urged his party to send him back to Parliament.

Among those who publicly acknowledged his Parliamentary diligence was senior BJP leader Arun Jaitley, who remarked that Rajeeve was "a Communist party member who used to come to this House very well prepared. Information about new things was received from him."

That reputation as a methodical legislator, combined

with his legal training and organisational grounding within the CPI(M), shaped his administrative style as Industries Minister.

MAJOR SHIFT

Rajeeve is widely credited within the ruling establishment for helping reduce industrial disruptions that once discouraged investors. A mix of legislative measures, administrative reforms and sustained engagement with industry bodies has been central to this shift.

The Minister points to the Invest Kerala Global Summit which, he says, attracted investment proposals exceeding ₹1.48 lakh crore — he presents this as evidence that negative investor perceptions are fading.

"We could not have attracted such investments if we were still ranked 28th in the Ease of Doing Business index and if negative perceptions among investors persisted."

The State's climb to the top position in the national ease-of-doing-business rankings in 2022, followed by continued strong performance in subsequent assessments, is cited by the government as validation of its industrial reforms.

He described the government's 'Year of Enterprises'

initiative as a historic intervention, saying that more than four lakh micro, small and medium enterprises were facilitated over the past four years.

The broader objective, he said, is to shift Kerala towards a knowledge-driven industrial ecosystem anchored in emerging sectors.

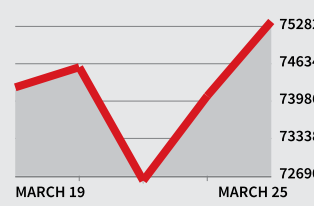
"Today, Kerala is emerging as a preferred destination, particularly for ESG investments, IT investments and high-tech manufacturing," he said.

While acknowledging that Kerala's global reputation historically rested on education and healthcare, Rajeeve said the government had worked to address gaps in the infrastructure and productive sectors. "The government has addressed this by focusing on two key areas: Improving the quality of education and healthcare while strengthening welfare measures for the most needy and simultaneously accelerating infrastructure development."

Rajeeve said the anti-incumbency sentiment is minimal. "The beneficial impact of our policies is visible in every household. People are looking for continuity to sustain these achievements."

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HITTING IT OUT OF PARK.

The sale of Rajasthan Royals and RCB is set to reshape commercials of the Indian Premier League ecosystem **p12**



TECHNOPHILE.

MacBook Neo delivers effortless performance in a clean, entry-level package **p4**

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QUICKLY.

WINNING STREAK

Markets surge as fears of a long W. Asia crisis ease



Mumbai: Markets closed higher for the second consecutive session on Wednesday as diplomatic signals between the US and Iran eased fears of a prolonged West Asian conflict. The BSE SENSEX gained 1,205 points or 1.63 per cent to close at 75,273.45, while the Nifty 50 rose 394 points or 1.72 per cent to settle at 23,306.45. **p8**

IN ONE VOICE

Govt-Opposition present united front on Gulf crisis

New Delhi: A "broad understanding" emerged between the government and the Opposition during an all-party meeting on Wednesday to present a united voice on the ongoing tensions in West Asia. Union Minister Kiren Rijiju said the government was able to address all concerns raised by Opposition leaders. The government shared information on the situation through a presentation by Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri. **p5**

Centre clears ₹28,850-crore modified UDAN flight plan

10-YEAR SCHEME. Will focus on enhancing connectivity to under-served/unserved areas

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

With the Union Cabinet on Wednesday approving a ₹28,850-crore modified UDAN, India is set to expand its aviation network through the next iteration of the Regional Connectivity Scheme. *businessline* was the first to report on the proposed revamp of the UDAN scheme and its key contours ahead of the Cabinet's approval.

The scheme will be implemented for 10 years from 2026-27 to 2035-36 with budgetary support.

100 NEW AIRPORTS

Announcing the Cabinet decision, Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnav said 100 new airports will be developed through a challenge-based approach with the States.

The scheme will cover 120 new destinations and target four crore passengers. Vaishnav stated that the scheme aimed to democratise air travel and improve regional connectivity across India.

Under the approved structure, the scheme will focus



WIDENING HORIZON. The scheme will cover 120 new destinations and target four crore passengers

on enhancing regional air connectivity to under-served and unserved areas while improving the viability and sustainability of regional aerodromes and airline operators. The framework includes the development of 100 airports at existing unserved airstrips, with a capital outlay of ₹12,159 crore over the next eight years.

HELIPORTS, WATER AERODROMES

Additionally, the scheme proposes operational support for aerodromes, with operation and maintenance funding capped at ₹3.06 crore per annum per airport and ₹0.9 crore per annum for heliports and water aero-

dromes, with a total estimated allocation of ₹2,577 crore.

Industry insiders said this support is to ensure that newly-developed airports remain functional during the initial years of low traffic.

The scheme includes the development of 200 modern helipads in hilly, remote, island and aspirational regions, with an outlay of ₹3.661 crore aimed at improving last-mile connectivity and emergency response.

VGF FOR AIRLINES

Apart from infrastructure development, the scheme includes viability gap funding support for airline operators, with an outlay of ₹10,043

crore over a 10-year period to support operations on regional routes.

Experts said this support is expected to help airlines sustain operations on routes that may not be immediately commercially viable.

AIRCRAFT BUYS

The scheme includes a provision for aircraft acquisition under the Atmanirbhar Bharat initiative, with plans to procure two HAL Dhruv helicopters for Pawan Hans and two HAL Dornier aircraft for Alliance Air. Sectoral analysts said the move could help strengthen fleet availability for operations in remote areas.

"The revised UDAN scheme comes at a moment when oil prices and jet fuel rates are expected to soar to unsustainable levels. UDAN as a scheme is centred on Central and State government subsidies and no matter how lucrative the scheme is for airlines and operators, the government must consider the scheme's efficacy in the backdrop of the rupee depreciating and rising jet fuel prices," said Mark D Martin of Martin Consulting.

Inflation target range to remain unchanged for 5 more years

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The Finance Ministry announced on Wednesday that the current inflation target range will remain unchanged for five years from April 1, 2026. This marks the third five-year term for the country's inflation-targeting framework.

The official notification clarifies that the inflation target will be maintained at 4 per cent, with a flexibility band ranging from a lower limit of 2 per cent to an upper limit of 6 per cent. This framework will be effective till March 31, 2031.

In accordance with Section 45ZA of the RBI Act, the Central government, in consultation with the RBI, is required to determine and notify the Consumer Price Index inflation target every five years. This policy framework was first inaugurated on August 5, 2016, establishing a primary target of 4 per cent with a tolerance band of 2 per cent to 6 per cent.

Following a renewal on March 31, 2021, the government has officially extended this same mandate for a third consecutive term from April 1, 2026.

Govt in big PNG push as LPG supply risks mount

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

With LPG supply risks rising as the West Asia conflict rages on and India's piped natural gas (PNG) base still at just 16.2 million consumers, compared with nearly 330 million LPG users, the government has moved decisively to accelerate PNG adoption in cities where the pipeline networks exist.

In a key policy shift, the Oil Ministry mandated that households in areas with PNG connectivity switch from LPG in three months or face disconnection, a move aimed at fast-tracking migration of nearly 60 lakh LPG consumers in the first phase.

Imported LPG accounts for 60 per cent of domestic consumption compared with natural gas, where imports meet roughly half of the country's needs. Officials also point to stronger supply visibility in natural gas, both from domestic output and diversified global sources.

FUEL STRATEGY

In a notification on Tuesday, the Ministry laid out a timeline requiring households in PNG network areas to shift to piped gas, signalling a decisive shift in urban fuel strategy.



The country's PNG base is just 16.2 million, compared with 330 million LPG users.

Although piped gas infrastructure is more predominant in the North and West, including Delhi-NCR, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat and Maharashtra, it is expanding in the South.

The government has been prioritising CNG and PNG infrastructure in Tamil Nadu, Karnataka (both GAIL), Andhra Pradesh and Telangana (both Bhagyanagar Gas).

The transition is gaining traction, with the government issuing about 2.5 lakh new PNG connections in the last 25 days while receiving a similar number of applications. Alongside, around 2.2 lakh LPG consumers have already migrated to PNG.

Officials estimate that nearly 60 lakh LPG consumers are located in areas where the PNG infrastructure is already available, making them immediate candidates for migration.

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TECH DIGEST.

Apple unveils Apple Business



Apple has announced Apple Business, a new all-in-one platform that includes key services companies need to effortlessly manage devices, equip team members with apps and tools, and get support from experts to run and grow efficiently and securely.

Apple Business offers built-in mobile device management (MDM), facilitating a comprehensive view of an organisation's Apple devices, settings and more from a single interface.

Customers can now set up business email, calendar and directory services with their own domain name for seamless and elevated communication and collaboration. Apple Business can help millions of companies grow their reach and connect with local customers across Apple Maps, Mail, Wallet, Siri and more. Apple Business will be available starting Tuesday, April 14.

Previously available as a subscription within Apple Business Essentials in the US, Apple Business includes new Blueprints to easily set up devices with preconfigured settings and apps, ensuring consistency and security and enabling zero-touch deployment for employees, so that new Apple products are ready to go out of the box.

Apple Business includes options to purchase upgraded iCloud storage and support with AppleCare+ for Business, and a companion Apple Business app will allow employees to install apps for work, and view colleague contact information.

Govt ties up with IICT and Google for AI skilling venture



The Ministry of Information & Broadcasting (MIB), in collaboration with the Indian Institute of Creative Technologies (IICT), has announced a national AI skilling initiative for the creative sector, in partnership with Google and YouTube. The programme will offer 15,000 scholarships aimed at building advanced, future-ready AI capabilities among India's next generation of creators, storytellers and digital professionals.

Anchored by the IICT under MIB's broader vision for strengthening India's creative economy, the initiative represents a significant institutional step towards integrating artificial intelligence into mainstream creative education. The programme is designed as a selective, impact-focused skilling pathway, tailored specifically for high-potential talent across media, entertainment, animation, gaming and digital storytelling.

The programme will be delivered in two phases — Phase I: Foundational Skills: Focused on building AI literacy at scale, 15,000 participants will receive scholarships for Google Career Certificates and Google Cloud's Gen AI learning paths; Phase II: For Specialisation, participants will advance to hands-on, project-based training.

IICT has designed a curriculum that integrates AI tools, creative workflows and platform-level best practices. This initiative builds on the 'Create with AI' programme, announced last year by IICT and YouTube.

HP launches AI PCs and more at HP Imagine 2026



At its flagship event, Imagine, in New York, HP unveiled a range of PCs, software and devices designed for AI workflows.

The major launch was HP IQ, which brings local, on-device intelligence and proximity-based connectivity together with enterprise manageability across select HP AI PCs and workplace devices.

The event saw the launch of HP Z Workstations and AI solutions. The HP Z8 Fury G6i is designed for the most demanding compute and AI workloads. With support for up to four NVIDIA RTX PROTM 6000 Blackwell Max-Q Workstation Edition GPUs and next-generation workstation Intel processors, the Z8 Fury is built for advanced AI development, visual effects and simulation workflows.

HP NearSense is a new software experience designed to make cross-device interoperability effortless. Teams can move work from device to device without interruptions.

On the gaming front, HP announced its next high-performance gaming devices with the new HyperX OMEN MAX 45L, HyperX OMEN 35L, expanded OMEN AI game support and new OMEN Gaming Hub updates.

Entry-level laptop done right

MACBOOK NEO. Premium build and smooth performance that doesn't skip a beat

Ashwin Rajagopalan

There's a Steve Jobs clip from the first iPad launch in 2010 that is seeing a lot of views over the past few weeks, coinciding with one of Apple's most significant launches of 2026. The MacBook Neo was the laptop we never thought Apple would make. A lot has changed since Jobs mocked cheap laptops and Netbooks (that had their moment between the late 2000s and early 2010s) in that clip — Apple didn't make its own laptop chips back then. The MacBook Neo is one of the boldest moves we've seen from Apple but like most things Apple, this is a calculated gamble. A MacBook that doesn't cut too many corners in its quest to open up a whole new market segment for Apple and a laptop that's likely to shake things up. Here's why:

DESIGN

The Neo will please those who are looking for an ultra-portable laptop. It's almost a perfect meeting place between the M1 MacBook Air and Pro design aesthetic. The Neo's design feels like a "greatest hits" compilation of Apple's hardware history. The screen bezels evoke a classic unibody MacBook Pro sensibility, while the rounded chassis echoes the modern, post-M1 MacBook Air aesthetic. Apple's decision to go with an aluminium chassis (and a range of colours) sets this apart in a market filled with plastic laptops that are more prone to creaking and hinge failure. It's a joy to be able to open this laptop with a single finger. The Neo also scores with its durability and repairability. iFixit rated the Neo as the most repairable Apple laptop in over a decade. The Neo replaces glue with screws for the battery and keyboard.

The typing experience is anchored by a 78-key (ANSI) or 79-key (ISO) layout, featuring a welcome row of 12 full-height function keys. However, the "base model blues" are real here: The 8/256 GB SKU omits the Touch ID sensor, a convenience reserved exclusively for the 8/512 GB tier. If you're moving from an older MacBook, you're likely to miss the illuminated keys. The total absence of keyboard back-lighting is a miss, especially for students and professionals who pull late-night sessions in dim environments.

Connectivity is concentrated entirely on the left side, housing two USB-C ports and a 3.5mm combo jack, alongside a side-firing speaker grille. A matching speaker grille is the only occupant of the right side of the laptop. A complete lack of ports on the right side can take some time getting used to, especially for first time MacBook users.

Siddharth Mathew Cherian

As tech brands have made their tablet launches a little more fixed over the years, a slow yet steady growth has been seen in the segment, driven by online learning and more. Xiaomi is one such brand that releases a tablet year on year and in true fashion, I have the Pad 8 in for review — the successor to last year's Pad 7. Here is my take on the device.

DESIGN

Measuring 5.75 mm thick and weighing 485 g, the aluminium chassis is slim enough to slip into a bag without feeling too heavy. The Pad 8 is available in Graphite Gray and Titanium Blue. I reviewed the Titanium blue variant, which features a matte metallic finish across the back and sides. This finish resists smudges effectively and strikes a professional balance, offering a sophisticated look without being over the top looks-wise.

DISPLAY

The Xiaomi Pad 8 features an 11.2-inch 3.2K 144Hz display that strikes a deliberate balance between portability and screen real estate. This form factor feels like the sweet spot for tablets, sitting perfectly between 7-inch and 13-inch extremes. There is also a Nano-Texture display variant available for the tablet.

Despite being an LCD, the panel does an admirable job of rendering true-to-life colours, proving to be a near-ideal canvas for media consumption. Contrast levels remain impressive for an LCD, especially when catching up on the latest season of *The Rookie* on Netflix. However, at this price point, the inclusion of an OLED or AMOLED panel would have provided even greater value for dedicated media enthusiasts.

SOUND

Sound from the quad speakers is a standout feature of the Xiaomi Pad



PUT TO TEST. Apple announced that the A18 Pro chip from the iPhone 16 Pro would power the MacBook Neo, and the results are impressive



Apple MacBook Neo colour line-up

cially for first time MacBook users. The Multi-Touch trackpad is distinct from the haptic "Force Touch" glass surfaces seen on MacBook Air and Pro models over the last decade. Instead, it opts for a traditional physical clicking mechanism. While it lacks that high-end haptic feel, it remains a far superior option compared to the flimsy plastic trackpads found on many Windows competitors in this price bracket. Every press on the trackpad surface yields a reassuring metallic click, and the cursor precision remains top-tier, ensuring that the Neo still feels like a premium tool during daily usage.

PERFORMANCE

Can a chip that we first experienced in a mobile phone power a laptop? That was one of the talking points when Apple announced that the A18 Pro chip from the iPhone 16 Pro would power the MacBook Neo. The MacBook Neo packs surprising power into its 13-inch frame; in everyday terms, it's a "mobile-first" heart beating inside a "laptop" body running MacOS and the results are impressive.

With a Geekbench 6 single-core score of 3,450 and a multi-core score of 7,993, the Neo feels incredibly snappy for daily tasks. Its Metal

score of 30,636 effectively puts its graphics performance on par with the original M1 MacBook Air. For the average user, this means you're getting proven, reliable laptop power in a device that stays cool and efficient — demonstrating that a smartphone chip can more than hold its own in a professional notebook setup. In real-world testing, the Neo is quite capable. It managed a heavy multitasking load of 20–25 Chrome tabs, including YouTube, Canva, Teams and a few others — alongside a DaVinci Resolve editing session.

While we noticed some background tab refreshing in Chrome, the machine handled a 2-minute 4K timeline with light graphics in DaVinci Resolve smoothly. It exported a 2-minute 4K clip in 1 minute and 18 seconds (extending to only 1:22 with graphics). More importantly, the playback remained fluid despite a random frame drop, which is surprising for a "non-pro" machine operating on limited memory. For document editing and marathon streaming sessions, 8GB of RAM is more than sufficient. However, power users will likely feel the ceiling quickly.

The Neo allows you to take advantage of Apple Intelligence tools and yet the 8GB of RAM seems a misstep in terms of long-term usage. The Neo is available in two con-



ASHWIN RAJAGOPALAN

figurations: 8/256 GB and 8/512 GB. Heavy duty users might need cloud storage or an external SSD. The 13-inch LED display (2408 x 1506 pixels / 219 PPI) hits a peak brightness of 500 nits. Colours are vibrant; this is a great binge-watch screen. I watched an episode of *Slow Horses* on Apple TV+ and the Neo impressed with its crisp visuals.

VERDICT

The MacBook Neo is one of the best laptops you can buy for under ₹70,000 (Students can buy it at ₹59,900), an entry-level MacBook done right. We like the premium build and the form factor as well as the immersive display. While a lot of focus is on students, we think the Neo is also a great option for professionals who need to make an impression at a client meeting. It packs enough fire power for most users with a smooth multi-tasking experience; we'd recommend this over an iPad for anyone whose workflows revolve more around content creation. While the limited RAM and lack of a backlit keyboard are among the downsides, it's packed with more hits than misses. You get the best of Apple's Mac OS and a battery that won't let you down, making it a perfect option for first-time Mac users.

● SNAPSHOT

Price: ₹69,900 onwards
Pros: Premium design and build, dependable battery, lightweight form, vibrant display
Cons: Only 8GB of RAM, No backlit keyboard

of a bundle — paired and powered worked well alongside the Xiaomi Pad 8.

CAMERA

The Xiaomi Pad 8 features a 13 MP rear camera and an 8 MP front camera, both designed with utility in mind. While tablets are not typically known for their primary cameras, the rear setup supports 4K video and includes dedicated modes for documents, making it a handy tool for scanning and quick captures. The selfie camera is reliable for video and Microsoft Teams calls.

BATTERY

The Xiaomi Pad 8 features a 9,200 mAh battery with 45W turbo charging support and, conveniently, ships with a 67W charger in the box. During the review period, the battery lasted nearly a week under mixed usage, which included streaming video, typing review notes and attending Microsoft Teams calls.

Charging the tablet from zero to 100 per cent took approximately 1 hour and 50 minutes. The Focus Pro keyboard draws power via pogo pins on the rear of the device, while the Focus Pen Pro charges magnetically when docked on the top right edge.

VERDICT

The Xiaomi Pad 8 balances size, performance and value starting at ₹43,999. While the use of an LCD display and camera quality aren't its strongest points, it offers reliable mid-to-high-tier performance, long battery life and strong productivity features, making it a solid alternative to the iPad 11th Gen and OnePlus Pad 3.

● SNAPSHOT

Price: ₹43,999 (8 + 128 GB), ₹48,999 (as reviewed)
Pros: Good mid-range performance, great battery life, good sound
Cons: LCD display, average cameras



Solid performance meets productivity

XIAOMI PAD 8. Striking the right chord between a slim form factor and heavy-duty performance

WELL-EQUIPPED. The Xiaomi Pad 8 features a 9,200 mAh battery with 45W turbo charging support and, conveniently, ships with a 67W charger in the box

8. Dolby Vision and Atmos tuning provide a significant value-add, ensuring the audio remains clear and retains its composure even at higher volumes.

While testing Tame Impala's *Dracula*, a recent earworm of mine, the quad speakers rendered the track beautifully. The layering of the electric guitar, bass, drums and synths remained distinct, with excellent vocal separation for Kevin Parker's soft, airy tone. The soundstage felt balanced across the top and bottom speakers on the tablet's frame, making for an immersive listening experience.

PERFORMANCE

Powered by the Snapdragon 8s Gen 4, the Xiaomi Pad 8 comes in 8 GB/128 GB or 12 GB/256 GB configurations; I tested the latter. In synthetic benchmarks, the processor

lands firmly in the mid-to-high tier and maintains impressive, sustained performance. Gaming was equally stable, with BGMI holding a steady 60 FPS without frame drops. Crucially, the chassis remained remarkably cool even during extended sessions — a significant advantage for a tablet of this slim form factor.

The OS is based off Xiaomi HyperOS 3, based on Android 16. It excels on the productivity front, arriving with minimal bloatware and focusing instead on functional tools such as Mi Canvas and WPS Office.

The integrated AI features for notetaking and voice-to-text transcription work reliably. Further, the upgraded Workstation Mode looks to offers an experience approaching the Samsung DeX. While not yet perfect, the floating windows and snapping remained utilitarian, but

the ability to connect to an external monitor via USB-C significantly enhances the long-term versatility of the device. When used with the Focus Pro Keyboard and Focus Pen Pro, the Pad 8 delivers a solid mobile office setup.

KEYBOARD AND STYLUS

The Focus Pro Keyboard lets you use the tablet in desk mode and was quite a sturdy folio cover for the tablet, along with keyboard functionality with keys firmly seated on the keyboard with no discernible gaps, offering a reassuring tactile response. Similarly, the Focus Pro pen was very intuitive, and featured a haptic motor to deliver precise feedback for every gesture. This is particularly effective within sketching apps such as Mi Canvas and others. Both accessories — which can be purchased separately or as part

Micro management

MFI credit guarantee scheme sets too many conditions

After growing at an annual rate of over 18 per cent in the five years from FY19 to FY24, microfinance lending has suffered a sharp setback in the last two years. The microfinance portfolio of banks and NBFCs (Non-Banking Finance Companies) shrank by 18 per cent in the nine months to December 2025, on top of a 14 per cent contraction in FY25.

Banks have halved their lending to microfinance institutions on asset quality and regulatory worries. However, with the microfinance loan book at barely ₹3.5 lakh crore today, there is an urgent need for credit flow to this sector to restart. The Credit Guarantee Scheme for Microfinance Institutions announced by the Centre, seems to be an attempt to nudge banks into lending to NBFCs and microfinance firms by shielding them from default risks. However, it sets one too many conditions to avail of the cover. Under it, the National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company (NCGTC) will provide credit guarantees worth ₹20,000 crore to banks or financial institutions against loans to NBFCs or microfinance firms that cater to micro borrowers, until June 30, 2026. NCGTC will guarantee against 70 per cent of defaults from loans to large NBFCs, 75 per cent to medium ones and 80 per cent to small firms for a maximum period of three years. While the guarantees offered are attractive, other terms and conditions attached to these loans seem restrictive.

To avail of the cover, banks/lending institutions need to ensure that the interest rates at which NBFCs or microfinance firms on-lend to their borrowers is capped at their EBLR (external benchmark linked lending rate) or MCLR (Marginal Cost of Funds-based Lending Rate) plus 2 per cent. They are also required to price loans 1 per cent below the rates they charged for the last six months. As microfinance loans are usually priced much higher in the market to factor in credit risks, it is unclear how NBFCs will demarcate loans under this scheme from their normal micro-loans, especially as this is a limited-period scheme. Even if this is possible, pricing a section of microfinance loans at a discount could distort borrower expectations. It needs to be noted that Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has since 2022, encouraged lenders to move to market-based pricing of their microfinance loans by doing away with earlier rate caps.

If they avail of the scheme, banks need to ensure that at least 5 per cent of their loans are disbursed to small NBFCs and 10 per cent to medium ones. As banks may like to take these calls based on prudent underwriting, this can be a deal-breaker. Banks are also expected to monitor microfinance lenders to ensure that they use the credit only to create fresh loans (and not rollover existing loans) and monitor adherence to the rate caps. Overall, banks may prefer giving up the credit guarantee, rather than adhere to these conditions. To step up credit flow, policymakers may need to look beyond banks to bond markets, where investors have the risk appetite to bankroll riskier lending.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

Iran war: energy, markets and a dangerous illusion
Whatever else Donald Trump's "pause" is, it is not a ceasefire. Iranian barrages targeted Israel, Gulf Arab states and northern Iraq on Tuesday, while Israeli and US warplanes struck across Iran. What Mr Trump's statement did was to narrow US targets to exclude power plants and energy infrastructure to calm jittery markets. But the fighting continues. With reports that the US is considering boots on the ground, Washington is waging war while searching for an exit – without a credible or unified negotiating position, as Israel's Benjamin Netanyahu pursues his own agenda. Mr Trump's strategy, if he has one, might be to soothe markets now – and launch a massive escalatory strike over the weekend when trading desks are closed, in the hope of forcing the Iranian regime to fracture or capitulate. LONDON, MARCH 24

CHINADAILY

Don't squander the opportunity for peace
A drawn-out United States-Israeli conflict with Iran serves no one's interest. A ceasefire and dialogue are the only way out. China, which is deeply concerned about the continued escalation and spillovers that have dealt a blow to regional and international peace and stability, calls on the relevant parties to end the hostilities immediately and return to the track of peace and dialogue as soon as possible. In support of this call, the country has been making dedicated diplomatic efforts to stem the tide of war. As part of these efforts, Foreign Minister Wang Yi had telephone talks with his Iranian counterpart Seyed Abbas Araghchi late on Tuesday, reiterating China's conviction that dialogue is always better than bloodshed and that all hot spot issues should be resolved through dialogue and negotiation, rather than through the use of force. MARCH 25, BEIJING

PN3, amidst fragile capital flows

FDI PUSH. The Centre looks keen to attract long-term investment from China to offset tepid domestic investment as well



Earlier this month, the Union government announced a major shift in its foreign direct investment (FDI) policy (see box for explainer on PN3). The latest amendments to FDI policy improved the conditions for potential investors from countries with which India shares its land border, in two ways. One, investors from these countries with non-controlling “Beneficial Ownership” of up to 10 per cent are allowed invest under the automatic route, subject to the applicable sectoral caps, entry routes, attendant conditions.

And two, processing of proposals for investments in specified sectors/activities of manufacturing in capital goods, electronic capital goods, electronic components, polysilicon and ingot-wafer, would be completed expeditiously, within 60 days. The indicative sectors are a subtle hint that the government is extending an olive branch to the Chinese investors, which is in keeping with the improvements in bilateral relations seen over the past few months.

The government expects the new guidelines, its latest move to attract foreign investments, to provide clarity and ease of doing business in India and facilitate investments which can contribute towards greater FDI inflows, access to new technologies, domestic value addition, expansion of domestic firms and integration with global supply chain.

Questions would arise regarding the timing of the new FDI guidelines, the government's latest attempt to attract long-term foreign investment into India, and as it seems, also from China. It is important to note that India-China relations have been going through a reset since last year, especially after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Tianjin for the Shanghai Cooperation Organization meeting in August 2025, his first visit to China in seven years.

Our view is the new guidelines are the government's response to the progressive weakening of net FDI inflows into India, which could worsen further due to the conflict in West Asia.

DIPPING FDI
Net FDI inflows, which according to the RBI, is the difference between the gross FDI inflows into India and the sum total of capital repatriation by foreign



WORRYING TREND. Disinvestments by foreign direct investors reached a record level of \$51.5 billion in 2024-25 (ISTOCKPHOTO)

investors and outward investment by Indian entities, have been at precariously low levels in the past two years. Net FDI inflows were well above \$40 billion until the pandemic but slipped to below \$1 billion in 2024-25, the lowest level since the turn of the millennium. Although during the nine months of the present fiscal year, net FDI inflows have increased to about \$4 billion, the situation remains a source of concern.

Despite healthy levels of annual gross inflows into India, of between \$70 and 80 billion, net FDI inflows have dropped to precipitous levels due to significant levels of outgo both by way of disinvestments by foreign investors, and India's overseas investments.

Disinvestments by foreign direct investors reached a record level of \$51.5 billion in 2024-25, up from \$27 billion in 2020-21, and from about \$11 billion in 2015-16. Disinvestments were nearly 64 per cent of gross FDI inflows in 2024-25 and are above 60 per cent in the current fiscal year as well, which is well above the 25 per cent threshold seen prior to the pandemic. FDI is considered as stable, long-term investment, and for it to become footloose is something that should concern policymakers.

OUTWARD FDI SURGE
As with disinvestment, so has India's outward foreign direct investments (OFDI) increased dramatically since the beginning of the decade. From about \$11 billion in 2020-21, OFDI exceeded \$28 billion in 2024-25. During the first nine months of 2025-26, OFDI was nearly 26 billion, over \$6 billion higher as compared to the previous fiscal. This sudden spurt in OFDI from India is not only surprising, but it is also counter intuitive. With the Indian economy

PN3 and the 2020 amendment

The Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) amended Press Note 3 (PN3) issued on April 17, 2020 and, therefore, the extant regulations on foreign direct investors from countries with which India shares its land borders. Prior to the issuance of PN3, citizens of Bangladesh and Pakistan, or entities incorporated in these countries, could invest in India only under the Government route.

Further, citizens of Pakistan or entities incorporated in Pakistan could invest in sectors/activities other than defence, space, atomic energy and sectors/activities prohibited for foreign investment. PN3 extended this restriction to countries sharing

its land border with India or where the “beneficial owner” of an investment into India is situated in or is a citizen of any such country.

This condition, disallowing the benefit of automatic route to FDI inflows from the target countries, was clearly targeted at China, the only one among these countries having substantial capacities to invest in India. The tightening of conditions on potential Chinese investments followed worsening of bilateral relations with the build-up of troops on India's northern border in Ladakh. India-China relations went into a freeze with the two armies clashing in Ladakh's Galwan Valley.

growing the fastest among the major economies, Indian investors should have been looking at opportunities at home rather than other destinations.

What is more, India's private sector has been generating record profits since the pandemic. Between 2020 and 2025, profits of India Inc grew three times faster than the country's GDP (http://bit.ly/4bBYDr). The comfortable balance sheet position of India Inc should also give them leverage to raise funds from the market.

The sudden spurt in outward FDI from India is puzzling, as one of the fastest growing economies in the world, Indian investors should be looking to invest at home than abroad

India's energy choices have been sub-optimal

Under US pressure, it moved away from Iranian oil earlier. Such choices may have started to hurt

Ritesh Kumar Singh

For years, Indian foreign policy has proudly invoked the doctrine of “strategic autonomy.” Yet as the Middle East crisis deepens in 2026, a sobering reality is emerging: New Delhi is paying a steep “appeasement tax” to Washington, while its primary regional rival, China, and its “all-weather” partner, Russia, reap the dividends of the chaos.

India imports roughly 85 per cent of the crude oil it consumes, leaving the economy deeply exposed to disruptions in global energy markets. Yet in recent years New Delhi has repeatedly aligned its oil purchases with pressure from the US — first by halting imports from Iran under sanctions and more recently by scaling back purchases of discounted Russian crude during trade tensions with Washington.

India should respond with alacrity to limited waivers from US to buy Iranian oil. India shouldn't voluntarily give up some of the cheapest and closest sources of energy while its competitors secure them.

SELECTIVE BLOCKADE
At the centre of the current crisis lies the Strait of Hormuz — the narrow waterway through which roughly one-fifth of global oil trade normally



OIL SUPPLIES. Need to assert strategic autonomy GETTY IMAGES

passes. Since the conflict escalated, Iranian forces have effectively turned the strait into a geopolitical filter. Attacks on commercial vessels, security threats and maritime disruptions have sharply reduced tanker traffic, forcing many ships to delay or avoid the route altogether.

Yet the disruption has been far from uniform. While shipments from Gulf producers such as Iraq and Saudi Arabia face growing obstacles, Iranian crude continues to pass through the strait to China.

In effect, the Strait of Hormuz allows Iran to squeeze rival exporters while ensuring its own oil keeps flowing to its most important buyer.

Geography makes Iran one of India's most natural energy partners. Iranian ports lie barely a week's sailing distance

from India's western refineries, making Iranian crude among the cheapest barrels to transport. By contrast, sourcing oil from the Atlantic basin — whether from Brazil or the US Gulf Coast — can require voyages lasting several weeks. Longer routes mean higher freight costs, higher insurance premiums and larger inventories for refiners. In stable markets those differences are manageable. In a geopolitical crisis centred on the Strait of Hormuz, they become decisive.

Even as Washington now signals flexibility through temporary waivers on Iranian oil, India seems to be reacting cautiously. Chinese buyers continue to purchase Iranian oil despite sanctions, relying on non-dollar payment systems, shadow tanker fleets and independent refineries willing to process sanctioned crude. While China secures discounted energy supplies, India often ends up paying higher prices for more distant barrels.

KREMLIN BENEFITS
If there is one country that clearly benefits from the current chaos, it is Russia. Russia's flagship export blend — Urals crude oil — which traded at steep discounts for much of the past two years, is now selling at a premium to Brent crude in deliveries to India as buyers scramble for alternatives to Middle Eastern supplies.

The longer the conflict persists and the longer Gulf oil flows remain constrained, the stronger Russia's position becomes in global energy markets. For India, it is the opposite. The longer the war drags on, the higher the cost of oil imports and the greater the economic penalty.

For India, turmoil in the Middle East carries consequences far beyond crude prices. The region is not only a major energy supplier but also one of India's largest sources of inward remittances and a key export destination. Prolonged instability therefore threatens two pillars of the Indian economy: affordable energy imports and steady trade and remittance flows.

Expensive oil feeds directly into inflation because fuel prices ripple across the economy through transportation and logistics costs. At the same time, slowing trade and remittance flows can place additional pressure on the rupee. The result could be higher inflation, sluggish exports and a weaker INR.

At some point, New Delhi must decide whether “strategic autonomy” is a slogan or a policy. Even as Washington begins to ease its stance through limited waivers on Iranian oil, it remains to be seen whether India acts decisively.

The writer is a business economist and CEO, Indonomics Consulting Private Ltd

● **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Divestment blues

This refers to the Editorial 'Selling strategy' (March 25). Even though IDBI Bank has recorded impressive performance in areas such as business growth, asset quality, and capital adequacy, as reflected in its stock price, but this has not helped in divesting the government stake. With the Centre and LIC being major stakeholders, the government must look to dilute its stake significantly through a competitive price mechanism rather than inviting bids

with a reserve price. This will help the Centre to get a better price. Since the portion of equity floating in the market is limited, the government must look to sell its stake through the market at an opportune time to gain a better market-determined price. PSU divestment must be pursued only through the market mechanism to ensure transparency and also to prevent the concentration of those equities in the hands of a few buyers. The government must enforce new

methods to optimise the value of stake sales.
VSK Pillai
Changanacherry (Kerala)

Peace ironies

This refers to 'Asim Munir: The world's most unlikely peacemaker' (March 25). It was intriguing to learn that amid missile strikes and drone attacks, Pakistan's Field Marshal Asim Munir offers himself as negotiator in Middle East talks. How come that a world renowned hawk is now trying

to adorn the role of some dove? Pakistan and Saudi Arabia have a defence deal whereby an attack on any one of them would be construed as attack on the other. Key US military assets in Saudi Arabia being targeted by Iran in this war, also complicates matters. Let Munir first douse the fire in Afghanistan.
Kumar Gupta
Panchkula (Haryana)

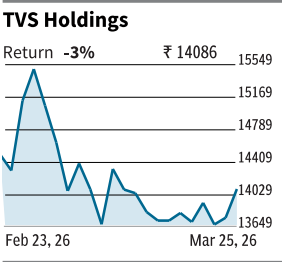
Dire situation
Till recently Prime Minister Narendra

Modi was telling people not to panic over the war in West Asia and energy crisis. But now he has observed that the issue is grave and will have serious consequences (March 25). One hopes that the seven empowered groups he has set up would help India handle the situation and secure India's energy needs. There is always light at the end of the tunnel.
S Ramakrishnasayee
Chennai



QUICKLY.

TVS Holdings declares interim dividend



Chennai: The board of directors of TVS Holdings, at its meeting held on Wednesday, declared an interim dividend of ₹86 per share (1,720 per cent) on 2,02,32,104 equity shares of ₹5 each fully paid-up, absorbing a sum of ₹174 crore for the financial year ending March 31, 2026. The record date for the purpose of interim dividend will be April 2, 2026, the company said in an exchange filing. “The dividend payment will be made within a period of 30 days from the declaration of interim dividend, as provided in the Companies Act, 2013,” the company added. **OUR BUREAU**

Cost accountants allowed to audit analysts, advisers

New Delhi: SEBI on Wednesday allowed members of the Institute of Cost Accountants of India to conduct the annual audit of research analysts and investment advisers, a move that will widen the pool of eligible professionals. Earlier, only members of the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India and the Institute of Company Secretaries of India were permitted to carry out such audits. Under the revised framework, research analysts and investment advisers are required to carry out an annual audit of their compliance with SEBI regulations within six months from the end of each financial year. The circulars come into force with immediate effect. **PI**

With West Asia war showing signs of easing, markets rise for the second day

FRIDAY’S CUES. All eyes will be on fresh diplomatic signals, crude oil movement and rupee stability

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

The markets closed higher for the second consecutive session on Wednesday as diplomatic signals between the US and Iran eased fears of a prolonged West Asian conflict.

The BSE Sensex gained 1,205 points or 1.63 per cent to close at 75,273.45, while the Nifty 50 advanced 394 points or 1.72 per cent to settle at 23,306.45. The broader market outperformed blue-chips, with the Nifty Midcap 100 rising 2.3 per cent and the Smallcap 100 climbing 2.6 per cent.

All sectoral indices closed in the green. Consumer durables led the gainers at 3.5 per cent, followed by realty



BETTER TIMES. The easing in oil prices provided additional support to equities by alleviating near-term inflation and supply concerns **REUTERS**

and PSU banks, each rising over 2.5 per cent.

GAINERS, LOSERS

Shriram Finance was the top gainer among Nifty 50 stocks at 5.8 per cent, followed by Titan (4.6 per cent) and

Grasim (4.2 per cent). Tech Mahindra was the biggest loser, declining 2 per cent, followed by Powergrid and TCS.

However, volatility index India VIX ended flat at 24.64. Some investors may have

bought hedges, given the two-day jump, said Akshay Chinchalkar, Managing Partner and Head of Markets Strategy, The Wealth Company.

Vishnu Kant Upadhyay, AVP, Research Advisory, Master Capital Services, said, “Sectorally, the pressure was most visible in downstream oil refiners, paint companies, tyre manufacturers and aviation stocks, as elevated crude prices could lead to margin compression.”

Brent crude fell sharply by around 5 per cent to the \$94-98 range.

“The easing in oil prices provided additional support to equities by alleviating near-term inflation and supply concerns,” said Siddhartha Khemka, Head of

Research, Motilal Oswal Financial Services.

Gold and silver also mirrored the risk-on mood with by surging nearly 4 per cent to \$4,556 per ounce and 4.8 per cent to \$73.12.

FPI selling persisted. Provisional data from exchanges revealed that FPIs were net sellers by ₹1,805.37 crore.

According to Chinchalkar, fresh longs were built in the front-month Nifty futures contract, while Bank Nifty futures saw short covering.

With the markets closed on Thursday for Ram Navami, participants will watch US-Iran developments closely. Friday’s session will likely reflect fresh diplomatic cues, with crude oil movement, rupee stability and RBI action remaining key variables to track.

Bernstein, UBS trim Nifty targets amid war worries

Madhu Balaji
Bengaluru

Heightened volatility and mounting headwinds prompted global and domestic brokerages to take a more cautious stance on Indian equities as the escalating West Asia conflict fuels crude oil volatility, inflation risks and clouds the outlook for growth and corporate earnings. While most firms believe the domestic structural story remains intact, near-term market direction is seen hinging on the duration of geopolitical tensions, the trajectory of oil prices and foreign capital flows, prompting several brokerages to pare index targets and reassess risk-reward.

‘GFC-LIKE RISKS’

Bernstein said the ongoing geopolitical shock could expose India’s macro vulnerabilities if elevated crude prices persist. It warned that a prolonged conflict could recreate conditions similar to the aftermath of the global financial crisis.

Early warning signs are already visible and a delay in rate cuts, weaker remittances from Gulf nations and continued foreign investor outflows could strain the balance of payments and shave 3-4 per cent off GDP growth.

The brokerage cut its year-end Nifty 50 target to 26,000, implying limited upside from current levels and maintained a neutral stance on equities.

UBS also downgraded Indian equities to ‘neutral’ from ‘attractive’, citing rising macro vulnerability to energy supply disruptions and persistent price pressures.

OTHER BROKERAGES

The brokerage said India’s heavy dependence on imported oil, LNG and LPG left the economy exposed to geopolitical chokepoints, particularly the Strait of Hormuz.

Bernstein cuts Nifty 50 year-end target to 26,000, while UBS turns neutral

Citi recently cut its year-end target for the Nifty 50 to 27,000 from 28,500, flagging rising risks to economic growth and corporate earnings. Nomura, too, slashed its December 2026 Nifty target by 15 per cent, bringing it down to 24,900 from 29,300.

BNP Paribas warned that key macro indicators such as the balance of payments, fiscal position, inflation and corporate earnings remain vulnerable to prolonged geopolitical stress.

In contrast, domestic brokerage Emkay Global staged a bullish perspective, maintaining its December 2026 Nifty target of 29,000 as it anticipates a sharp “peace dividend” bounce following any de-escalatory news. It expects India to be a major beneficiary of easing oil prices due to its heavy reliance on imported crude and projects Brent Crude to retreat to \$75-80 per barrel. The brokerage added that domestic markets are poised for a smart recovery after recent foreign investor selling dragged the Nifty 50 lower, with easing crude prices and more reasonable valuations likely to attract flows back into equities. It expects the rupee and bond markets to strengthen alongside equities as investors quickly price in the peace dividend, even though real economic normalisation could take a few months.

Emkay Global cautioned that supply-chain disruptions and energy infrastructure damage may weigh on near-term earnings, estimating a modest impact on FY27 profits, with small- and mid-cap firms facing slightly higher but temporary pressure.

BROKER’S CALL.

BNP Paribas India

HDFC BANK (OUTPERFORM)
Target: ₹1,500
CMP: ₹781.70

The resignation-related release of ex-Chairman of HDFC Bank, Atanu Chakraborty, was not the ultimate benign farewell that one typically expects in such cases. It mentioned, “...concerns over certain happenings and practices, not aligning with his personal values and ethics”. Given the specific context of a bank, that too India’s largest private bank, these words do carry weight.

The near-automatic instinct to assume the worst, is understandable. In fact, the moderate price reaction in a weak market is a testimony to the fact that reputation wise HDFC Bank is a ‘little more equal’ than most other banks.

The bank has been able to rope in Keki Mistry as interim Chairman with blessings of the regulator. This is critical given the bank’s systemic importance. It also held a call to clarify its stance on all issues and we view the wide variety of board members and executives in attendance as a clear show of unity and confidence.

The management came out with the upfront statement that no operational or material issues were brought to their notice. Multiple board members mentioned that in their meeting with the outgoing Chairman, they had queried him multiple times about the nature/details of his misgivings but did not receive any response.

We feel it is quite likely that the outgoing chairman might have had differences of opinion with the management group.

SBI Securities

NALCO (BUY)

Target: ₹420.9
CMP: ₹367.15
NALCO is an integrated aluminium producer encompassing mining ore to metal. It is one of the lowest-cost producers of Alumina. Capacities for respective segment is as follows: Bauxite mining – 68,25,000 tonnes per annum (tpa) (North and Central Block) and 31,50,000 tpa (South Block); Alumina production – 22,75,000 tpa (normative capacity at 21,00,000 tpa); Power production – 1,200 MW; Aluminium metal production – 4,60,000 tpa; and Wind Power – 198 MW. The company is aggressively pursuing a 0.5 million tpa (mtpa) capacity expansion. Detailed project report is expected to be ready by June/July 2026. Groundwork and capex are expected to kick-start from FY27 and the commissioning is targeted around December 2030. The estimated combined capex is ₹30,000 crore. NALCO ramped up production at its Utkal D coal block to 2 mtpa in FY24, helping reduce power and fuel costs. The power plant requires about 7.2 mtpa of coal. For FY26, it targets producing 4 mtpa from the Utkal D & E blocks, which is expected to generate cost savings of ₹200-250 per tonne. For FY26, NALCO plans to incur a capex of ₹1,700 crore, rising to ₹1,800-2,000 crore in FY27. The new 1-mtpa refinery is expected to start commissioning in June 2026. While the full capacity will stabilise by December 2026, a realistic production target of 0.3 mtpa is aimed for FY27. At CMP, the stock is trading at 7.6x/7.2x of its FY26E/FY27E EV/EBITDA based on Bloomberg consensus estimates.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

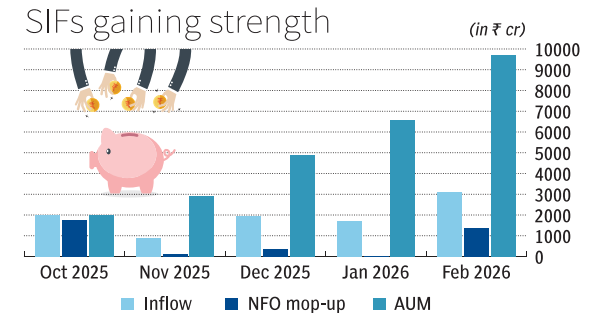
SIF asset base swells to ₹9,712 crore in short span

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

One year after market regulator SEBI established norms, the Specialised Investment Funds (SIFs) are off to a slow and steady start, amassing assets under management of ₹9,712 crore and net inflow of ₹9,696 crore in the last five months since the Association of Mutual Funds in India (AMFI) started tracking data.

SIFs are sophisticated investment products, which require a minimum investment of ₹10 lakh and are strategically placed between mutual funds and AIFs. Unlike traditional MFs, SIFs can take unhedged or “naked” positions in derivatives up to 25 per cent of the portfolio to benefit from market swings.

The hybrid long-short fund has been the most popular with six schemes man-



aging ₹7,389 crore; three equity long-short funds and two equity ex-top 100 short funds have combined assets of ₹2,322 crore.

NO DEBT STRATEGY

However, MF houses have not launched any fund on debt-oriented strategy. The inflow also indicates that funds are managing to attract investments only during the new fund offer stage.

Though SEBI approved SIF norms last February, the

need for a separate brand identity delayed its launch. As of March, 13 MF houses have received SEBI approval, including SBI (Magnum SIF), Edelweiss (Altiva SIF), Quant (qSIF), Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC (Apex SIF), ICICI MF (iSIF) and Bandhan MF (Arudha SIF).

Radhika Gupta, MD & CEO, Edelweiss Asset Management, said SIFs were growing at an expected pace and will gain traction if the value proposition is made

clear and delivered effectively. “We are planning to launch other products in the category as well, with more aggressive risk profiles, since Altiva’s first product, the Hybrid Long-Short fund, has been conservative. Our focus remains on giving consumers a good experience and building trust in the SIF brand,” said Gupta.

Bhautik Ambani, Associate Director & Chief Executive Officer, AlphaGrep, said in the current environment of elevated volatility and market dispersion, SIFs are structurally better placed to navigate uncertainty than traditional long-only funds.

However, investors need to evaluate each SIF carefully as strategies can differ significantly, particularly in terms of derivatives usage and market beta, making manager approach and risk framework critical to outcomes, he said.

Gold ETFs outpace Nifty 50 returns across horizons

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Gold exchange-traded funds (ETFs) continued to shine as attractive long-term investment vehicles, delivering robust returns across multiple time horizons, according to data compiled by ACEMF as of March 23, 2026. They outpaced equity benchmarks over the period.

The performance highlighted the growing appeal of gold ETFs amid sustained investor interest and their resilient performance compared with traditional equity benchmarks. According to the ACEMF dataset, most gold ETF schemes delivered strong returns within a year, underscoring strong momentum in gold-linked investment products.

On a one-year CAGR basis, most gold ETFs delivered returns in excess of 50 per cent, reflecting the sharp rally in gold prices and strong investor demand for safe-haven assets.

On a trailing basis, several funds also posted compelling multi-year returns,

Shining glory

Scheme Name	1 Year	3 Years	5 Years	7 Years	10 Years	15 Years
Axis Gold ETF	52.5	30.7	23.8	22.0	15.2	11.9
HDFC Gold ETF	51.6	30.2	23.7	21.8	15.4	12.1
ICICI Pru Gold ETF	52.8	30.8	23.8	21.9	15.3	12.1
Invesco India Gold ETF	51.3	30.1	23.8	22.0	15.5	12.2
Kotak Gold ETF	52.5	30.2	23.7	22.0	15.4	12.1
Nippon India ETF Gold BeES	52.3	30.4	23.4	21.6	15.3	12.0
Quantum Gold Fund ETF	52.5	30.2	23.7	21.8	15.3	12.1
SBI Gold ETF	52.4	30	23.7	21.9	15.3	12.1
Union Gold ETF	51.9					
UTI Gold ETF	52.5	30.8	24.0	22.0	15.5	12.2
NIFTY 50 - TRI	-2.5	10.9	10.0	11.4	12.7	11.2

ACEMF: All figures as of March 23, 2026.

with many exhibiting double-digit annualised growth over five- and seven-year periods.

Among the leading performers, Aditya Birla SL Gold ETF, Nippon India ETF Gold BeES, ICICI Pru Gold ETF, HDFC Gold ETF and Zerodha Gold ETF demonstrated consistent returns, with one-year growth rates hovering above 50 per cent.

However, longer horizons reflected gold’s sustained appeal amid market volatility and inflationary pressures. On a three-year CAGR basis, gold ETFs delivered annualised returns of around 30 per cent, while five-year CAGR returns stood near 24 per cent. Over seven years, annu-

alised gains were close to 22 per cent.

According to the data, gold ETFs have significantly outpaced traditional equity benchmarks over similar periods. For instance, the Nifty 50 Total Return Index (TRI) posted a modest negative return over one year and a mid-single-digit to low double-digit gains over three- and five-year windows, markedly lower than gold-linked products.

An analysis of 10-year terms shows gold ETFs delivering annualised growth north of 15 per cent, as against around 12.7 per cent for the Nifty 50-TRI. This underscores gold’s effective-

SEBI proposes IT Resilience Index for MIIs

Our Bureau
Mumbai

SEBI on Wednesday proposed a framework to introduce an IT Resilience Index (ITRI) for Market Infrastructure Institutions (MIIs) to strengthen oversight of critical technology systems in the securities market.

In a consultation paper, SEBI said the proposed index would offer a structured, system-driven mechanism to assess the health and robustness of IT systems across stock exchanges, clearing corporations and depositories. The regulator has invited public comments on the framework until April 15.

The ITRI aims to provide periodic insights into system performance and help MIIs identify vulnerabilities and areas for improvement.

ness as a portfolio diversifier and hedge against broader market fluctuations over cycles.

SIP GROWTH

Performance through the SIP route was equally compelling. Monthly SIP of ₹1,000 grew to roughly ₹14,000 in one year, implying XIRR returns of about 38-40 per cent.

Over longer horizons, the compounding impact becomes more visible, with the corpus rising to around ₹61,000 in three years, nearly ₹1.97 lakh in seven years, about ₹3.45 lakh in 10 years and over ₹6 lakh in 15 years.

Annualised SIP returns moderate gradually with tenure but remain attractive at roughly 20 per cent over 10 years and about 15 per cent over 15 years.

Market analysts noted that gold ETFs appealed to risk-averse investors seeking stability amid macroeconomic uncertainties, supply chain shifts and shifting monetary policy expectations globally. Gold’s traditional status as a safe-haven asset has contributed to steady inflows, particularly during periods of elevated equity market volatility.

Nifty 50 Movers					▲ 394.05 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
HDFC Bank	782.30	58.39	15.54	11.26	
L&T	3649.30	34.14	26.45	4.03	
State Bank	1060.60	27.12	11.31	4.14	
Bharti Airtel	1834.90	20.05	28.24	4.91	
Bajaj Finance	882.75	19.66	29.98	2.21	
M&M	3128.10	18.96	23.01	2.63	
Axis Bank	1222.10	18.48	14.36	3.30	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	956.00	16.10	19.66	1.26	
ICICI Bank	1259.70	13.32	15.91	8.47	
Titan	4039.30	12.89	19.94	1.87	
Tata Ultra Cement	11204.00	11.44	43.08	1.25	
Tata Steel	196.65	10.63	26.91	1.53	
Sun Pharma	1795.40	9.78	39.33	1.79	
Hind Unilever	2134.80	9.70	49.88	1.78	
ITC	295.70	9.41	17.89	2.68	
Grasim Ind	2647.80	8.25	19.02	0.95	
Int'l Global	4294.70	7.14	51.71	0.91	
Maruti Suzuki	12711.00	7.11	26.76	1.57	
Kotak Bank	371.10	6.86	19.63	2.57	
Eternal Ltd.	242.18	6.68	1011.74	1.64	
Trent Ltd.	3478.90	5.51	76.35	0.73	
Dr Reddy's Lab	1300.70	5.49	19.66	0.75	
Asian Paints	228.00	5.39	55.50	0.97	
Bajaj Finserv	1746.20	5.24	14.53	0.94	
Adani Ports	1375.90	5.13	25.37	0.96	
JSW Steel	1156.00	4.60	36.40	1.02	
Hindalco	868.65	4.44	12.14	1.18	
Adani Enter	1886.60	3.93	15.41	0.46	
Apollo Hosp	7580.50	3.78	58.42	0.73	
Eicher Motors	6992.50	3.67	35.86	1.95	
Bajaj Auto	9048.50	3.66	28.44	0.94	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	237.35	3.34	93.96	0.73	
Nestle India	1204.10	3.29	71.19	0.81	
Max Healthcare	988.20	3.10	67.74	0.69	
Tata Motors PV	317.95	3.10	43.24	0.63	
Cipla	1244.40	3.09	22.16	1.67	
NTPC	378.40	2.96	14.78	1.69	
HDFC Life	612.90	2.33	69.96	0.62	
Reliance Ind	1413.10	1.93	19.56	8.98	
HCL Tech	1381.30	1.85	22.76	1.37	
ONGC	270.20	1.83	7.56	0.99	
SBI Life	1851.80	1.56	74.90	0.78	
Coal India	645.70	0.80	9.19	0.65	
Infosys	1279.10	0.61	18.52	4.22	
Tata Consumer Product	1056.10	0.43	71.02	0.65	
Wipro	189.05	0.19	14.87	0.51	
Bharat Elec	413.45	-0.79	50.68	1.39	
Tech Mahindra	1408.50	-3.37	30.06	0.84	
PowerGrid Corp	295.00	-3.97	17.67	1.28	
TCS	2377.40	-4.79	17.93	2.29	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

▲ 1,259.90 pts.

	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Vedanta	669.65	91.87	15.80	5.36
Cholamandalam&Fin	1473.80	69.66	25.66	2.94
Avenueuper	3910.88	68.18	88.75	2.72
Briran Beverages .	5041.45	53.79	44.34	2.59
Power & Ind Sol	692.25	51.40	40.26	2.24
Vitatum India	4647.00	47.24	56.29	3.14
Tvs Motor Corp .	3543.20	44.73	55.13	3.92
Adani Power .	153.65	41.90	26.22	2.86
Gedrej Consumer	1039.38	40.48	58.40	1.97
Shree Cement	24230.00	36.31	48.67	1.53
Adani Hotels Co .	617.30	34.92	40.26	2.56
Canara Bank	136.53	34.19	6.73	2.17
Tata Power	390.70	29.98	24.93	3.09
Lci Lombard Cg	1770.39	29.19	32.84	2.02
Punjab Natk Bank	1110.07	29.07	7.08	1.79
Pindind	281.20	25.51	59.83	2.00
Bajaj Holdings	9554.00	28.19	11.85	1.95
Hindus Zinc	517.70	26.88	18.93	1.96
Sarnwardmotherinternatn	1131.23	26.65	32.81	2.37
Siemens	3101.39	26.38	69.66	1.29
Ajanta Cements	421.80	26.07	21.19	1.21
Havells	1268.60	25.88	33.69	1.25
Rural Ecl	277.20	25.86	5.00	1.93
Dlf	534.35	25.69	29.87	1.62
Jindal Steel	1143.05	25.11	57.83	2.01
Solar Industries	12890.00	24.56	76.40	1.48
Adani Energy Solutions .	590.40	24.04	49.51	1.62
Ultimate	4219.00	22.65	26.34	1.88
Siemens Energy India .	2771.40	22.13	83.55	1.16
Power Finance	403.45	20.53	3.99	2.77
Indian Oilcorp	1405.20	20.40	5.38	2.48
Jsw Energy .	494.30	16.58	33.38	1.25
Larsen	129.10	14.92	9.32	0.82
Bpcl	284.55	13.38	5.02	2.60
Adani Green Corp .	853.80	13.11	75.77	1.23
Zyduslifesciences	903.70	12.99	18.09	1.07
Torrent Pharma	4297.50	12.83	64.02	1.12
Indian Railway Finance Corp	95.24	12.72	10.76	0.80
Axis Bank	129.20	12.38	10.67	0.84
Info Edge I	998.6	12.36	38.41	1.83
Bank Of Baroda	272.70	12.25	7.18	3.39
Hyundai Motor India .	1885.50	11.12	26.46	1.27
Hindustaneraonautics	3069.40	8.77	27.29	3.28
Bank	63.90	8.07	33.51	2.24
Abb India	629.50	7.95	78.06	1.54
Macrotech Developers .	733.85	6.29	21.91	0.97
Bajaj Housing Finance	79.13	1.07	26.61	0.35
Mazagon Dock	2255.90	0.66	37.81	0.81
Divis Lab	6014.50	-4.38	64.41	3.60
United Spirits	1311.60	-14.53	55.46	1.83

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

Rocketlane's Series C funding raises \$60 million

Chennai: Chennai and US-based Rocketlane, an AI-powered professional services automation platform, has raised \$60 million in a Series C funding round led by Insight Partners. The latest round brought the total capital raised by the firm to \$105 million. The company said it will use the proceeds to expand the capabilities of Nitro, its platform for professional services teams. **OUR BUREAU**

BonV Aer, ParaZero tie up for 'drone catcher' tech



Mumbai: Odisha-based drone manufacturer BonV Aero has entered into a pact with ParaZero Technologies to bring the latter's counter-drone system to cater to defence and security agencies. The tie up gives BonV Aero exclusive rights to deploy the system "DefendAir", which functions as a drone catcher, in the domestic market now and subsequently manufacture it locally, the company said. The alliance also covers DropAir, designed for autonomous delivery in high-altitude and remote terrain, it said. **PII**

Paisalo Digital adds Indian Overseas Bank as its BC

Mumbai: Paisalo Digital Limited announced on Wednesday that it has been appointed as a business correspondent (BC) partner for Indian Overseas Bank (IOB), expanding its Banking-as-a-Service (BaaS) platform that already includes the State Bank of India and Bank of India. The stock closed at ₹34.21 on the NSE on March 25, down 0.26 per cent from the previous close of ₹34.30. **OUR BUREAU**

Construction costs may rise 10-12% due to crude price surge

Aishwarya Kumar

Rising crude oil prices are beginning to ripple through India's real estate sector, and the bill is landing squarely on the construction site. Developers are reporting a 10-12 per cent increase in input cost due to global supply chain disruptions. Steel prices have surged roughly 20 per cent, from ₹62,000 to ₹72,000 per tonne — which translates to an additional ₹50 per sq ft in high-rise construction costs. PVC pipes have seen an even steeper rise of 25 per cent; petroleum-dependent materials such as tiles are also under pressure. Aluminium has, for now, remained relatively stable, largely due to legacy supplier contracts cushioning the immediate shocks. The freight situation has

RBI scraps treasury bill bids of ₹35,000 cr

THE REASON. March alone saw liquidity surplus of ₹2.5-3 lakh cr

Our Bureau

Mumbai The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) rejected all bids it received at the auction of Treasury Bills aggregating ₹35,000 crore on Wednesday in the backdrop of the government receiving inflows by way of GST and advance tax collections and market players placing bids at relatively higher yields. Market experts said the last time the RBI rejected all the bids at the T-Bill auction was in February 2025. The RBI, on behalf of the government, conducted auction of 91-day T-Bill (for raising ₹15,000 crore), 182-day T-Bill (₹12,000 crore) and 364-day T-Bill (₹8,000 crore).

ENOUGH LIQUIDITY Under the competitive bidding, the Central bank received 79 bids aggregating ₹21,698 crore at the auction of the 91-day T-Bill; 104 bids aggregating ₹28,776 crore at the auction of the 182-day T-Bill; and 90 bids aggregating ₹15,675 crore at the auction



NOT A FIRST. The last time the RBI rejected all the bids at the T-Bill auction was in February 2025 **REUTERS**

of the 364-day T-Bill. The RBI rejected all the bids as the government has sufficient liquidity following mid-month tax collections and bidders, especially banks, demanding higher yields in view of lower surplus in the banking system. V Rama Chandra Reddy, Head — Treasury, Karur Vysya Bank, observed that the bids at the T-Bill auctions may have been rejected as the government is having good liquidity on account of tax collections and the market players placing bids at higher yields due to lower liquidity surplus. There was a

RBI received 79 bids aggregating ₹21,698 crore at the auction of the 91-day T-Bill; 104 bids aggregating ₹28,776 crore at the auction of 182-day T-Bill

liquidity surplus of about ₹2.5-3.0 lakh crore in the banking system in the beginning of March 2026 and it has come down to about ₹61,600 crore as on March 24.

Kotak Mahindra Bank in the eye of ₹150-cr FD fraud linked to Haryana govt

Our Bureau

Mumbai The Haryana government has reportedly found discrepancy in fixed deposits (FDs), aggregating to about ₹150 crore, at Kotak Mahindra Bank which were placed by the Panchkula Municipal Corporation. *The Tribune*, in a report quoting sources, said the Panchkula MC had deposited the amount at the bank branch in Sector 11, Panchkula. "Recently, when officials approached the bank about the maturity of a fixed de-

posit (FD) worth ₹58 crore, they were told that it did not exist. Upon checking all accounts, it was found that the discrepancies exceeded over ₹150 crore," per the report. A bank spokesperson said following instructions from the municipal corporation, the bank initiated a detailed reconciliation of FDs and linked bank accounts maintained by the Corporation. **'WITH DUE PROCESS'** Based on records examined so far, the bank has found that all account opening processes, KYC documentation, authorised signatories and instructions received from

the municipal corporation were in order, and that the accounts and transactions were handled in strict adherence to due process. "A significant portion of the amount under review has already been reconciled with the municipal corporation, and the process is continuing in an orderly manner," the spokesperson said. Further, the bank has filed a formal complaint with the Panchkula police. **IDFC FIRST AND AU SFB** It is cooperating with the municipal corporation, government authorities and law enforcement agencies, per

Cabinet clears 47% emissions intensity cut goal by 2035

Reuters

The Union Cabinet has approved a target to cut emissions intensity by 47 per cent by 2035 from 2005 levels as part of its formal climate pledges under the Paris Agreement, Information Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said on Wednesday. India, the world's fastest-growing major economy, aims to lift the share of installed clean-power capacity to 60 per cent over the next decade from 52 per cent now, Vaishnaw said, adding that it had already reduced emissions intensity by 36 per cent between 2005 and 2020.

US EXIT FROM PACT India's absolute emissions continue to rise alongside economic growth, but it often cites its low per-capita emissions to argue that developed nations must do more to fight climate change. The US rolling back climate policies under President Donald Trump has added pressure on others. The United Nations expects global greenhouse gas emissions to fall over the next 10 years if countries meet their climate pledges.

PM Jan Dhan Yojana's total balance crosses ₹3 lakh cr-mark

G Naga Sridhar

Hyderabad Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY), the Centre's flagship scheme for financial inclusion, has surpassed ₹3 lakh crore in total balance ahead of the closure of the current financial year. Jan Dhan accounts logged a total balance of ₹3,02,778 crore as on March 11, against ₹2.6 lakh crore in the year-ago period. The scheme has 57.86 crore account holders compared to 55 crore last year, as per the government data. Rural and semi-urban centres accounted for 45.23 crore beneficiaries, while 12.63 crore beneficiaries are from urban metro centre bank branches. According to bankers, the average balance in the accounts is around ₹4,700.

BANK ACCOUNT PUSH On the factors behind the continued surge in total balance, a senior SBI official said, "Sustained efforts by the public sector banks in opening the new accounts and a campaign to revive dormant accounts during the current fiscal have helped gain greater traction



POWER OF NUMBERS. Women from both rural and urban areas account for a majority of the beneficiaries under the scheme, which offers no-frills accounts **GIRI KVS**

in PMJDY." Last year, the Department of Financial Services launched an initiative to promote financial inclusion at the grassroots — in the panchayats — and to revive dormant accounts in major schemes of the government, including PMJDY. Women from both rural and urban areas account for majority beneficiaries under the scheme, which offers no-frills accounts with benefits of Rupay debit cards. As per government data, at the end of the third quarter of the current financial year 15 crore Jan Dhan accounts

were inoperative out of a total of 57 crore accounts under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY). **DIGITAL REVOLUTION** Prasanna Tantri, Executive Director, Center for Analytical Finance, Indian School of Business, said, "PMJDY is the backbone of the digital revolution in India, as it has turned out to be one of the most successful financial inclusion schemes taken up so far. I hope that the data generated by the accounts are used by lenders to improve access to credit."



the spokesperson. The aforementioned development comes on the heels of a similar scam involving Haryana government accounts (FDs aggregating ₹590 crore) with IDFC

First Bank that came to light last month. IDFC First Bank said against the initial estimate of principal of ₹590 crore, it received claims and paid the net principal amount of ₹645 crore — exceeding by ₹55 crore. Following the de-empanement of AU Small Finance Bank and IDFC First Bank by the government of Haryana last month, the former clarified that the State government account was opened with an initial credit of ₹25 crore transferred from a large private sector bank. Further, additional credits of ₹47 crore were subsequently received through

multiple transactions from another private sector bank, which has recently provided public disclosure of unauthorised and suspected fraudulent activities, AU SFB said in a regulatory filing. Out of the total credits received in the government account, ₹47 crore were transferred to the customer account through 14 transactions, it added. AU SFB said the government account was closed on January 15, and the outstanding balance of ₹25 crore along with accrued interest was transferred back to the large private sector bank.

Sundaram Home Finance expands 'emerging biz' in South TN



D Lakshminarayanan, MD, Sundaram Home Finance **KSJ**

Our Bureau

Chennai Sundaram Home Finance on Wednesday announced the expansion of its presence in the emerging business (EB) segment in South Tamil Nadu. The company opened new EB branches in Sankaran Koil and Ambasamudram this week. Over the next 12 months, it plans to open another 5 branches in South TN. The EB segment comprises affordable housing finance and working capital loans. It is targeting disbursements of ₹200 crore in South TN in the segment next year. D Lakshminarayanan, MD, Sundaram Home Finance, said in a statement, "We had diversified into the EB segment in October 2022, with a foray first into South Tamil Nadu, setting up new branches in and around Madurai. In the last 3.5 years, we have established a strong base in South TN with 15 EB branches. We are now looking to strengthen our presence in South TN, penetrating deeper into tier-4 and -5 towns in this region."

Rupee closes at record low of 93.9/US dollar

Our Bureau

Mumbai The rupee closed at a record low against the US dollar on Wednesday in the backdrop of rising crude oil prices due to the ongoing geopolitical tensions in West Asia and FPI outflows from equity markets, even as the RBI's intervention ensured that it did not breach the 94 mark. The rupee ended at 93.9775 per dollar, against the previous close of 93.87. **CASCADING EFFECT** Radhika Rao, Senior Economist & Executive Director, DBS Bank, said the rupee's weakness reflects a cyclical adjustment in response to evolving global conditions, primarily a shift in underlying external sector dynam-

ics. Amit Pabari, MD, CR Forex Advisors, observed that the geopolitical situation in West Asia is far from resolved. He said Iran's denial on any active negotiations with the US is keeping uncertainty alive. "The effect of global tensions is now reflecting in domestic data as well. HSBC India Composite PMI dropped sharply to 56.5 in March from 58.9, coming below expectations. This marks the slowest pace of expansion since October 2022, with both manufacturing and services seeing moderation. "The global conflict is not just affecting markets, but is also slowing down business activity in India. And that adds another layer of pressure on the rupee," Pabari said.

QED Investors keen to deploy \$250-300 million in India

Our Bureau

Bengaluru QED Investors is sharpening its focus on India, committing to deploy \$250-300 million over the next two fund cycles as it sees the market transition from a "story of promise" to one of tangible outcomes, backed by a maturing start-up and public markets ecosystem. The US-based fintech-focused venture capital firm, which has invested over \$220 million across Asia-Pacific, counts India as its core geography in the region, with eight of its 14 investments anchored in the country. "What has deepened our conviction is that India has moved from being a market of promise to a market of consequence," Sandeep Patil, Partner and Head of Asia at QED Investors said,



pointing to a steady rise in technology IPOs and increasing participation from public market investors. **JEKYLL & HYDE** QED's India thesis is underpinned by structural tailwinds, including strong GDP growth, a large domestic consumption base, and public infrastructure such as Aadhaar and UPI, which have lowered the cost of building

and scaling financial services businesses. The investor is increasingly leaning into artificial intelligence as a core theme, even as it acknowledges the dual nature of the technology. "AI is a classic Jekyll-and-Hyde story in India," Patil added, stating that while it can drive productivity, exports and innovation, it could also disrupt services employment and widen income disparities. **INDIA-BUILT** In fintech, QED sees AI unlocking opportunities across both enterprise and consumer segments. On the enterprise side, use cases such as fraud detection, identity verification and credit underwriting are expected to see significant gains from AI-led automation. On the consumer side, conversational and voice-based interfaces could drive the next wave of adoption, particularly among users less comfortable with traditional app-based banking. The firm is also betting on the rise of "India-built, global-first" companies. **GLOBALLY EXPORTABLE** At the same time, QED remains cautious about regulatory risks. The firm said this makes it critical to back "regulatory-minded founders" who can navigate the evolving landscape. Going forward, QED plans to focus on high-ARPU segments, AI-native financial services, and scalable business models that can extend beyond India. "If you solve complex financial problems in India, those solutions are often exportable globally," he noted.

HFCL defence arm logs ₹1,570 cr export order book

Our Bureau

Mumbai HFCL Ltd (HFCL) on Wednesday announced expansion of its defence business via its subsidiary HFCL Advance Systems Private Limited (HASPL), stating a confirmed export order book of ₹1,570 crore for aeronautic manufacturing. HASPL will acquire 100 per cent stake in an engineering and precision manufacturing company, Spiral EHL Engineering Limited (Spiral). The latter will in turn acquire the Aerostructure and Aeronautics business of Defsys Solutions Private Limited (Defsys) on a slump sale basis. HASPL will also acquire 80 per cent stake of HFCL in

Raddef Private Ltd, a radar technology company, strengthening indigenous defence capabilities. The pacts are to be executed on or before May 31, with financial closing expected within the current calendar year.

thehindu **businessline.**

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RISL invites bids from the eligible bidders for Short Term RFP for Selection of Agency for Annual Technical Support (ATS) of HCL AppScan and Procurement of Security Audit Tools with ATS for 3 Year (**UBN: RIS2526SLOB00096**). Total estimated cost is INR 1.40 Cr. The details can be seen on the websites:
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Raj. Sanmadi/C/25/23210 Additional Director

TATA
TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)

The Tata Power Company Limited, Smart Center of Procurement Excellence, 3rd Floor, Sahar Receiving Station, Near Hotel Leela, Sahar Airport Road Andheri (E), Mumbai 400 059, Maharashtra, India (Board Line: 022-67173917) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)

The Tata Power Company Limited invites tender from eligible vendors for the following tender package (Two-part Bidding).
(A) SITC for 33KV GIS along with associated equipment at Badlapur Receiving Station. (**Package Ref: CC26NK054**)
(B) Two Years Out Line Agreement for Man lifter services required at project sites for at Badlapur, Kalyan, Saiset, Dharavi, Worli, Powai and Ghatkopar project locations (**Package Ref: CC26AM006**).
(C) Three years Outline Agreement for Air-Conditioned Outsourced Patrol Van services for transmission Line Camp at Borivali, Saiset and Trombay camp for overhead line maintenance job (**Package Ref: CC26AM012**).

Interested and eligible bidders to submit Tender Fee and Authorization Letter before **1500 hrs. Thursday, 02nd April 2026**.
For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Also, all future corrigendum's if any, to the said tender will be published on Tender section of above website (**Tata Power → Business Associates → Tender Documents**) only.

QUICKLY.

Gold up as war uncertainty persists



Gold rose more than 1 per cent on Wednesday, buoyed by a drop in oil prices, even as uncertainty surrounding the Middle East conflict lingered. Spot gold was up 1.6 per cent to \$4,546.59 per ounce as of 1300 GMT. US gold futures for April delivery jumped 3.3 per cent to \$4,545.40. REUTERS

Copper stable on demand, Iran ceasefire talks

London: Copper prices rose after reports the US was seeking a ceasefire in the Iran war and due to firmer Chinese demand, but the market was wary after Tehran denied there were any negotiations. Benchmark three-month copper on the LME climbed 1.1 per cent to \$12,234 a tonne. Nickel was the strongest performer, advancing 3.4 per cent to \$17,525. REUTERS

Crude oil slips down on ceasefire hopes



London: Crude oil prices sank about 5 per cent after reports that the US had sent Iran a 15-point proposal aimed at ending the war. Brent crude futures were down \$6.08 to \$98.41 a barrel by 1200 GMT, while US WTI crude futures were down \$5.09 at \$87.26. Both benchmarks rose nearly 5 per cent on Tuesday. REUTERS

As global fertilizer rates rise, India eyes price clause

RINGFENCING. Such a move will help in overcoming the volatility in prices being witnessed at present; there is also no hedging mechanism

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

As the country gears up to meet fertilizer demand for the ensuing monsoon season crops, companies are considering incorporating “floor and ceiling” price in annual fertilizer contracts with suppliers of di-ammonium phosphate (DAP), muriate of potash (MOP) and complex fertilizers. This will ensure that volatility, like at present, is avoided to a large extent. “Volatility in fertilizer prices have become too frequent, and there has to be some mechanism to at least partially insulate any shock like the current one. There is no futures trading of fertilizers anywhere as supplies are limited and buyers can-

not hedge the risk in this supplier-dominated market,” said the CEO of a leading Indian company dealing with urea, DAP, potash and complex fertilizers. Though the outcome will depend on how the negotiation proceeds, still the price factor can be brought into the contract, he said, adding that most companies are not in a hurry to renew their annual import contracts with suppliers even as the current financial year is about to end. “At current global prices, no negotiation can take place on what should be either the floor price or ceiling price,” he pointed out.

NO NEW UREA TENDER
Floor price is the minimum guaranteed rate which suppliers will get when prices dip and ceiling price is the



SUPPLY WAIT. Even as the government is banking on supplies from Russia — which may take about 45 days to reach Indian ports — no fresh tender for urea has been issued since Feb 18

maximum Indian buyers will pay for the product in case of a spurt in prices, he said. Meanwhile, even as the government is betting on supplies from Russia, which may take about 45 days to reach Indian ports, no fresh

tender for urea has been issued after the RCF came up with the last one on February 18, before the war began on February 28. The government has constituted a panel of experts representing top officials of

public sector firms NFL, IPL, RCF and HURL to advise it on the time and volume of urea that can be imported. “The government agreed to buy about 1 million tonnes of urea from the last RCF tender at \$508 (West Coast delivery) and \$512 (East Coast delivery) for supply to be completed by March 31, though there will be delay now. But it would be difficult to source urea even at \$750/tonne now as global prices have zoomed,” said a senior executive of a company who participated in the bid. Similarly, global DAP rates have exceeded \$800/tonne and MOP \$370-400/tonne, much higher than their pre-war rates of \$650 and \$290, respectively.

UREA OUTPUT DOUBTS
On the other hand, the gov-

ernment is committed to try to meet kharif demand of fertilizers, saying the country has higher stock compared to the previous year. However, doubts remain about domestic production of urea due to the tight supply of natural gas. “Through a combination of domestic production hikes and a sophisticated global procurement strategy, the government has moved to insulate Indian farmers from global supply chain volatilities,” the Department of Fertilizers said last week. As of March 19, urea stock was 61.14 lakh tonnes (lt) against 55.22 lt, DAP 24.24 lt against 11.85 lt, complex 57.21 lt against 34.44 lt and SSP 24.80 lt against 23.15 lt. Stock of only MOP is lower at 12.65 lt from 14.13 lt, it said.

In the last kharif season, the requirement of urea was estimated at 185.4 lt whereas the sales rose by 4 per cent to 193.2 lt. The fertilizer demand for kharif 2026 is yet to be estimated. Since there are no signs of the war ending and when the Strait of Hormuz will open, fertilizer companies doubt if domestic production of urea this kharif would match last year’s level of 144.8 lt (April-September) even if 70 per cent of committed gas supply is achieved. “If there is 30-40 per cent lower production, that amounts to an availability of 150-160 lt (excluding fresh import in the season) of urea after factoring 60 lt of the opening stock,” said an expert, cautioning a demand gap of 30-40 lt.

China’s rejection of Indian rice: Trade dispute, quality issue or something else?

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Exporters and experts have expressed surprise over the rejection of Indian rice by China on the ground of containing genetically modified organisms (GMO), wondering how it is possible when India does not grow any GM food crop and there is a court order banning the manufacture, sale and import of GM foods. The Genetic Engineering Appraisal Committee (GEAC), the legal body to allow commercial cultivation of genetically modified (GM) crops in India, for the first time in October 2022 allowed the release of a GM food crop — mustard hybrid DMH-11. However, the Su-



preme Court stayed its commercial release, though it allowed ICAR to conduct trials.

FSSAI YET TO NOTIFY
Secondly, while hearing a public interest litigation (PIL) petition in the Rajasthan High Court last year, food safety regulator FSSAI said GM foods could not yet be regulated as mandated

under Section 22(2) of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006 (FSS Act). The High Court has banned the manufacture, sale and import of GM foods in India until strict regulatory standards are established. As the FSSAI plans to regulate GM food in India, it had issued notices seeking public comments on the Food Safety and Standards (Genetically Modified Foods) Regulations from time to time, but is yet to notify it. In terms of quantity, export to China is not much as India exported over 14 million tonnes (mt) of non-basmati rice to all countries in 2024-25. But China’s decision to open its market for India in 2020-21 (with 3,31,571 tonnes of rice trade) after it removed those

curbs was seen as an opportunity to expand. Experts do not see China’s decision to impact Indian rice in any other country as they consider it more as a bargaining point amid the geo-political conflicts after India became the world’s largest rice producer, relegating China to second position in 2024-25. Since the import of rice from India in the first 10 months is higher than the whole of 2024-25, China may have wanted to stop it, said an exporter, adding that the reason of GMO contamination was “bizarre”. Former Agriculture Commissioner JS Sandhu said, “The ICAR can certify that there is no GMO rice variety recommended for cultivation.”

IIT-Ropar’s Annam.AI to set up weather intelligence network

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Annam.AI, the Centre of Excellence in artificial intelligence for agriculture at IIT-Ropar, is establishing a scalable weather intelligence network for India. As part of this, Annam.AI has initiated the deployment of 100 advanced weather stations, beginning with Punjab as the first implementation hub. Annam.AI has been established by the Ministry of Education at the Indian Institute of Technology, Ropar. The AI-based weather stations, provided at no cost, will deliver hyperlocal, real-time weather data to farmers, enabling precise decisions on sowing, irrigation and crop protection. Designed as a model for nationwide expansion, the

initiative aims to reduce climate-related risks and improve farm productivity, according to a statement.

DATA-DRIVEN FARMING
Being developed as a digital public good for Indian agriculture, Annam.AI is building scalable agricultural AI intelligence technologies designed to make data-driven farming accessible across the country. The initiative, which is supported by the Ministry of Education, is being implemented in phases, with initial deployments laying the foundation for expansion across several States, including Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Kerala, Odisha, Bihar, Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Maharashtra. To ensure optimal utilisation of this technology, Annam.AI will also roll out

fully-funded AI training for 10,000 students, rural youth, and agri-professionals. The skilling programme is designed to build on-ground capabilities and create a strong pipeline of individuals equipped to apply AI in agriculture at scale. At the Smart Agri Summit 2026, Pushpendra Singh, Project Director of Annam.AI and Dean of IIT-Ropar, said: “At Annam.AI, our focus is on bringing together research, technology and on-ground implementation to solve real challenges faced by farmers.” “By combining real-time data with scientific insights, we aim to make farming more productive, sustainable and climate resilient. Through these initiatives, we are enabling a more technology-driven and resilient agricultural ecosystem in India,” he added.

Short copper futures if price rises to ₹1,180

Akhil Nallamathu
bl. research bureau

Copper futures witnessed considerable volatility over the past few sessions and is now trading at ₹1,134 per kg. Since the March contract is set to expire on March 30 (Monday), we shall consider April futures, which are now trading at ₹1,152. The April futures, after dropping 7.3 per cent last week, have gained 2.9 per cent so far this week. The immediate barrier (falling trendline resistance) can be seen at ₹1,182. Just above this is the resistance at ₹1,200, where the 21-day moving average coincides. Therefore, the ongoing rally is likely to be capped



between ₹1,182 and ₹1,200. Once the downtrend restarts, copper futures could decline to retest the prior low of ₹1,067. On the other hand, if the barrier at ₹1,200 is breached, the near-term outlook could turn positive, which could lift the contract to ₹1,260 and then possibly to ₹1,300.

COMMODITY CALL.

TRADE STRATEGY
Stay out for now. Short copper futures (April) if the price rises to ₹1,180. Target and stop-loss can be ₹1,070 and ₹1,215, respectively.

Maharashtra plans multi-department panel to tackle recurring onion crisis

Our Bureau
Pune

Facing a recurring glut-and-crash cycle in onion prices, the Maharashtra government has initiated steps towards both immediate relief and structural reforms for onion growers. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Wednesday announced the formation of a high-level committee to address the issue. The panel will comprise the Additional Chief Secretaries of the Agriculture and Finance departments, along with the Secretary of the Marketing Department. It has been tasked with recommending immediate interventions to support farmers hit by falling prices, while also outlining long-term strategies to stabilise the sector. Highlighting the need for



structural correction, Fadnavis said the government will engage with the Centre on key trade-related issues, including curbing malpractices in onion trading and boosting exports to ensure price stability. A meeting with Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal is expected soon. The move comes amid rising concerns over increased onion output without commensurate mar-

ket expansion, leading to price volatility. Officials noted that intermediaries purchasing onions from farmers and reselling them to agencies such as Nafed had been eroding farmer margins, a practice the government aims to curb. **CROP DIVERSIFICATION**
The committee will also explore crop diversification in major onion-producing districts including Nashik, Pune, Ahilyanagar and Solapur. The State plans to pilot diversification as early as the upcoming kharif season, alongside efforts to improve varietal selection and productivity within onion cultivation itself. Fadnavis stressed that shifting farmers toward more remunerative crops could help rebalance supply over the next two to three years.

KhetiBuddy sets foot in Europe via local partner

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Pune-based startup firm KhetiBuddy Agritech Pvt Ltd has set foot in Europe through a local partner in France, even as it has enrolled clients in Canada, the company’s CEO Vinay Nair said. “We have a few clients in Canada. We are based out of Niagara Falls in Canada. We have offices in the UAE too,” he told *businessline* in an on-line interaction. Though KhetiBuddy’s work could be touching the lives of 3 lakh farmers, it is not working directly with them. It operates on four pillars — farm management, post-harvest, ERP and compliance. “For example, in Canada, wineries have a contract with all the grape farmers. So we would actually be deploying the solution for the winery.



Vinay Nair , CEO, KhetiBuddy Agritech

But as a part of it, we do have a mobile app which the farmers actually use,” the CEO said.

ENGAGING FARMERS
The services farmers actually engage in would be in terms of data, capturing growth and forecasts. Agri-business will then monitor how the production is progressing. “For a winery, it would be in terms of how much grapes are coming and their quality

in terms of manufacturing wine. We have people in the potato value chain where they’re actually looking at potato yield and quality,” said Nair. Working with agri-business, the company indirectly provides farmers details on crop yield, production, traceability, quality and crop advisory. Most of these are done through its white label app, which the companies it works with operate on their brand name. The apps are connected to KhetiBuddy’s crop advisory and this provides insights on the on-farm activities. The agribusinesses have their agronomist, and they actually work with the farmers. The start-up is looking to expand further, including globally, after having worked with various agri-input companies, food processors and governments over the past three years.

As KhetiBuddy has case studies and success stories, the CEO said it is time to look for expansion. KhetiBuddy is working with the Maharashtra government and the World Bank on a project called POCRA, which is on climate resilient agriculture. There is a strong push from some States to promote regenerative agriculture, he said, adding that there is resistance from farmers as the yield tends to drop during transition. Stating that the Maharashtra government is pushing hard on regenerative agriculture, he said one of the challenges is that the quality of soil is deteriorating. Comparing Indian soil with that available in Canada, he said the soil organic carbon in the North American nation is 4-5 per cent, where it is around 0.5 per cent here.

With 10 lakh litres a day, women SHGs lead dairy push in 31 districts of Uttar Pradesh

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Women groups from 31 districts in Uttar Pradesh are collecting around 10 lakh litres of milk daily, according to the State government. A media statement by the State government said that women groups, active across 31 districts, were collecting around 10 lakh litres of milk daily, not only increasing production but also generating a massive business of about ₹5,000 crore. This has infused new energy into the rural economy and significantly increased the income of women. **SHG INVOLVEMENT**
Women from more than 6,000 villages are associated with the initiative.



PROFITABLE CHURN. In addition to increasing production, the women are generating a massive business of about ₹5,000 cr

Organised through self-help groups (SHGs), these women are actively involved in the entire value chain, including milk procurement, processing and marketing. The statement said this model is providing employ-

ment to women and is also establishing them as entrepreneurs. **REDUCING MIGRATION**
It is reducing migration from villages while accelerating economic activities at the

QUICKLY.

In Calcutta HC, poll panel defends officers' transfers

Kolkata: The Election Commission told the Calcutta High Court that it is within its powers to transfer and post officers for the conduct of free and fair elections. Making submissions before a division bench in a PIL challenging the transfer of IAS and IPS officers in West Bengal by the Election Commission, its counsel stated that the petition is a camouflaged service matter and cannot be treated as a public interest litigation. **PTI**

Imported coal plants to run at full capacity from April

New Delhi: The Power Ministry is believed to have directed imported coal-based thermal plants to operate at full capacity for three months from April 1 to avoid any electricity shortage amid the estimated peak demand of 270 GW during the summer. Sources said that in letters to imported coal-based plants, the Power Ministry invoked Section 11 of the Electricity Act, asking them to run at full capacity. **PTI**

Govt introduces FCRA amendments as Finance Bill, Opposition flags concern

MOVING FAST. While the option was exercised to expedite the passage of the Bill, members ask why the rush

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

The government on Wednesday introduced the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, which seeks to provide oversight framework over foreign funding, enhance transparency and accountability, in the Lok Sabha as a Finance Bill under Article 117 Clause (1) of the Constitution, inviting sharp objections from the Opposition.

Union Minister of State for Home Nityanand Rai introduced the Bill and stated that certain provisions of the existing Act of 2010 needed clarity for administrative functioning so that it is transparent, ensures proper utilisation of funds received from abroad, has clear provisions to deal with issues and is in the interest of the nation.

He cautioned that the Modi government will not spare those engaged in forced religious conversion through foreign funding.

Reacting to the government's decision, Congress MP Manish Tiwari told *businessline*: "There is no justification to bring the FCRA Bill, 2026, as a Finance Bill. It is also contradictory as per their own position."

The 'Financial Memorandum' articulated in the Bill said, "The provisions of the proposed legislation do not involve any expenditure, either recurring or non-recurring, from and out of the Consolidated Fund of India."

"On one hand, the government is introducing it as a Finance Bill and, on the other, it is saying that there is no provision involving any expenditure in the legislation. This is contradictory," Tiwari said.

And why would the gov-



Minister of State for Home Nityanand Rai introduced the Bill during the second part of the Budget Session **ANI**

ernment not want to take this legislation to the Rajya Sabha (a Finance Bill does not need to go through the Upper House) is another question, he asked.

Countering the Opposition's charges, including that from Trinamool Congress member Pratima Mondal, that the Bill is "dangerous", Rai asserted that it is "indeed dangerous" for those who engage in forced religious conversion using foreign

contributions, as well as to individuals who abuse foreign funding for personal gain.

TO STOP FUND MISUSE

"The Modi government will not tolerate any misutilisation of foreign funding and will take strong action against such elements," he said.

Under the 'Statement of Objects and Reasons' for bringing the amendment to

the Act, the MHA said, "Over the period, certain operational and legal gaps have been identified, particularly in relation to the management of foreign contribution and assets created therefrom in cases where registration is cancelled, surrendered or otherwise ceases."

The Bill stated that Section 15 of the Act provides for vesting of assets, but the absence of a comprehensive framework for supervision, management and disposal of such assets had led to administrative uncertainty and scope for misuse.

Further, the multiplicity of investigations, inconsistency in penalties, the absence of timelines for utilisation, a lack of express provision for cessation of registration, and ambiguity regarding the treatment of assets during suspension had resulted in implementation challenges.

India's data centre capacity to grow 4x by 2030: CareEdge Ratings



MARKET SHARE. India's share in the global data centre market was around 4% in 2025, with a current capacity of 1.2 GW

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

India's data centre capacity is expected to increase to around 4 GW by FY30, with a large underlying investment potential of ₹1.5 lakh crore over the period ending FY30, according to CareEdge Ratings.

The data centre capacity per million internet users remains lower at 1.2 MW per million users, compared with the world average of 5 MW per million users. Digitisation, India's cost competitiveness in building data centres and the increasing adoption of AI are key factors driving growth in data centres. India's share in the global Data Centre market is approximately 4 per cent in 2025, with a current capacity of 1.2 GW.

CAPACITY SURGE

India's co-location data centre capacity has registered major growth since FY21 and doubled to 1.2 GW during FY22-FY25. With continued capacity growth and sustained absorption levels, the industry is expected to see a revenue CAGR of around 24 per cent during FY26-FY30.

Puja Jalan, Director CareEdge Ratings, said, "The industry is in an upswing with high capex, fundraising capability of strong sponsors and large equity investments targeted to Indian data

centre entities. The industry is likely to witness a revenue CAGR of 24 per cent during FY26-30, with steady-state margins ranging between 40 per cent and 42 per cent. The AI-led demand shall catapult the growth story. However, power infrastructure support is critical to realise the industry's potential. Also, the capability to manage cash flows amid rising costs and escalating commissioning timelines shall be key to sustenance."

CareEdge Ratings noted that India had attained digital parity with the world average, despite a low data centre share, implying growth potential. It estimated an investment of ₹1.5 lakh crore for the above-mentioned capacity augmentation during FY26-30. In addition, tenants are expected to spend 1.5x-2x of this amount on IT equipment, taking the overall investment potential to nearly ₹3-4 lakh crore.

The cost of constructing and operating data centres here is significantly lower compared with global peers. India's construction costs are roughly 30-40 per cent lower than in China and the US, supported by relatively lower land prices and benefits from competitive electricity tariffs. These factors, combined with supportive government measures, make India an attractive destination for hyperscalers and global cloud providers.

'Reforms driven by conviction, not compulsion; Budget backs middle class, MSMEs'

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Wednesday said the government is pursuing reforms out of "conviction" rather than compulsion, while asserting that the Budget for 2026-27 contains substantial measures aimed at the middle class and the MSMEs.

Replying to the debate on the Finance Bill in the Lok Sabha, which was later passed with 32 amendments, Sitharaman said the legislation reflects a clear reform philosophy and growth strategy. The Bill will now move to the Rajya Sabha before becoming law. It seeks to

give effect to the Centre's financial proposals for the financial year 2026-27.

"India is moving forward with reform not out of compulsion, which is what happened earlier, but out of conviction, with clarity, confidence and commitment," Sitharaman said.

She outlined five guiding principles of the Finance Bill, including trust-based tax administration, ease of living for citizens, empowerment of farmers, MSMEs and cooperatives, strengthening India as a global business hub, and seamless trade facilitation alongside customs reforms.

Responding to criticism over rising public debt, Sitharaman said the government had laid down a clear



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman speaking in the Lok Sabha **ANI**

glide path to reduce the debt-to-GDP ratio to 50 per cent (plus or minus one per cent) by 2030-31. "Since 2008, the world's overall debt burden has increased 41 per cent," she said, adding that India had reduced "its total debt burden by 4 per cent of its GDP."

Drawing comparisons with global peers, she said, "India's combined figure, the debt-to-GDP figure, is 83 per cent approximately. It is also on a declining path, that too after Covid."

MIDDLE-CLASS RELIEF

Rejecting opposition charges that the middle class had been overlooked, Sitharaman listed several measures, including a reduction in Tax Collected at Source (TCS) on payments under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS) for foreign education and medical treatment. TCS on overseas tour packages has been cut to 2 per cent from 20 per cent earlier.

The Finance Bill also provides customs duty ex-

emption on 17 critical drugs and duty-free import of medicines for personal use.

To ease compliance for taxpayers, the government has allowed the filing of updated income tax returns even where reassessment proceedings have begun, and introduced a foreign asset disclosure scheme targeted at small taxpayers.

To reduce disputes at airports, tariffs on gifts and personal items brought into India have been rationalised. "These measures are meant to facilitate middle-class taxpayers and ordinary citizens."

Countering criticism from DMK member Arun Nehru that GST rate cuts in September 2025 had not yielded results, Sitharaman cited strong

automobile sales data. Retail passenger vehicle sales recorded a 26.1 per cent increase, the highest-ever for any February, with rural sales rising 34 per cent and urban sales growing 21 per cent.

She added that GST collections mirrored this demand recovery, with y-o-y growth of 6.1 per cent in December 2025, 6.2 per cent in January 2026, and 8.1 per cent in February 2026. Overall GST growth stood at 8.3 per cent for 2025-26. Tamil Nadu's GST revenues also showed robust growth, recording an 8 per cent expansion in December 2025, a 5 per cent increase in January 2026, and a sharp 18 per cent increase in February 2026 following the SGST settlement.

Puravankara has over 33 msf of residential projects in pipeline

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Bengaluru-based Puravankara is set to launch about 33 million sq ft of residential projects over the next couple of years as it scales up its development pipeline.

The developer is targeting a broader pipeline of around 51 msf, with a total gross development value (GDV) of over ₹55,000 crore, spanning projects that are either under development, awaiting approvals or in advanced design stages.

The planned launches will be largely concentrated in South India and Mumbai, where the company has been stepping up its presence.

The company indicated that most land parcels for these projects had been secured, with a significant portion of upfront costs, primarily land acquisition, already incurred.

Puravankara's portfolio



Ashish Puravankara, MD, Puravankara Ltd

currently comprises a mix of ongoing and upcoming residential developments, with commercial projects forming a smaller part of its overall pipeline.

The company's strategy continues to focus on housing across segments, with price points ranging from mid-income to premium and luxury offerings, particularly in high-value markets such as Mumbai.

For the period ended, 9MFY26, the company reported pre-sales of ₹3,859

crore and customer collections of ₹3,045 crore.

Ashish Puravankara, Managing Director, Puravankara Ltd, told *businessline* that the company currently has about 4 msf of commercial space, of which 2.2 msf is expected to be ready in the next two months.

"We have companies that are now visiting, and we are running a couple of RFPs as well. We have an additional 1.8 to 2 msf that we will be pouring concrete on," he said, adding that the company expects steady year-on-year growth in this segment.

He noted that the company will remain selective in commercial expansion. "We will be choosy in terms of city and location. A significant portion of our current commercial portfolio is in North Bengaluru, on Bellary Road. We believe it is a sunrise destination, with infrastructure, metro connectivity and a well-developed ecosystem," he said.

Gujarat loses 45% of Central grants in FY25: CAG report

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Gujarat's annual grants from the Centre plunged 45 per cent to ₹14,127 crore in FY25, largely on account of the phase-out of GST compensation, along with the steep decline in Finance Commission transfers and Centrally sponsored scheme grants, a CAG report tabled in the Assembly on Wednesday shows.

An analysis of the grants-in-aid from the Centre showed that Finance Commission transfers declined 21 per cent to ₹4,160 crore in FY25 from ₹5,258 crore in FY24, while Centrally sponsored scheme grants fell 9 per cent to ₹8,624 crore from ₹9,468 crore.

However, the biggest drop was seen in the "other grants" section that included GST compensation, which fell by nearly 88 per cent to ₹1,342 crore in FY25 compared to ₹10,831 crore in the previous year. Collectively, this created a shortfall



STEEP DIP. Total central grants to Gujarat nearly halved since FY21, falling 48% from ₹27,178 crore to ₹14,127 crore in FY25

of over ₹11,400 crore against Budget Estimates.

"Grants-in-aid registered a significant shortfall against Budget Estimates due to phasing out of GST compensation, resulting in a decrease of ₹11,429.96 crore over previous year," the CAG stated in its report.

STRUCTURAL SHIFT

Over the longer term, total Central grants to Gujarat have nearly halved since

FY21, falling 48 per cent to ₹14,127 crore in FY25 from ₹27,178 crore, while grants-in-aid as a share of the GSDP shrunk from 1.68 per cent to just 0.53 per cent, reflecting the declining relative contribution of the Centre to the State's finances.

Sector-specific impacts were uneven during FY25. Grants for Saksham Anganwadi and POSHAN 2.0 fell 47 per cent year-on-year to

₹601 crore, while the National Health Programme and the National Urban Health Mission grants declined 9.5 per cent to ₹839 crore compared with FY24.

On the upside, schemes such as the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana - Rural and Urban Rejuvenation Mission saw strong growth, rising 133 per cent, 176 per cent and 10 per cent respectively during FY25 over the previous fiscal year.

However, the sharp fall in Central finances highlights a structural shift in Gujarat's finances, increasing its reliance on internal revenue collection and borrowings.

The CAG report highlighted that the end of GST compensation, lower Centrally sponsored scheme funding and reduced Finance Commission transfers would put pressure on Gujarat's fiscal management, compelling the State to lean more on its own revenue collection and strategic borrowings to meet developmental and welfare priorities.

Parliament passes Bill amending law on protection and rights of transgenders

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Parliament on Wednesday passed a Bill to amend a law on the protection and rights of transgender persons that proposes excluding social orientations from the ambit of the statute, with the Rajya Sabha giving its nod. The Bill, which seeks to amend the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Act, 2019, provides for graded punishment based on the gravity of harm inflicted on such people. The bill was passed in the Lok Sabha on Tuesday.

Replying to the debate on the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026, in the Upper House, Social Justice and Empowerment Minister Virendra Kumar said the legislation aims to take along all segments of society together. He said the Bill aims to protect those who face discrimination due to biological issues.

Maharashtra govt reviews VRS row at Bajaj Electronics unit

Our Bureau
Pune

The Maharashtra government has stepped in to review a dispute over a voluntary retirement scheme (VRS) at Bajaj Electronics Ltd's facility in Wadi Varhe, Igatpuri taluka of Nashik district, amid allegations of coercion of workers. Labour Minister Akash Fundkar chaired a meeting to assess the situation, asserting that the State is committed to ensuring that no injustice is meted out to employees. He directed both the company management and workers' representatives to submit their statements by March 31.

The company rolled out the VRS in February 2024. A section of workers

claimed the scheme was not entirely voluntary and involved element of pressure. The management has maintained that, due to operational constraints, work in original roles is currently unavailable, and has indicated readiness to offer alternative employment arrangements.

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QUICKLY.

Udemy-Coursera arm merger gets CCI nod

New Delhi: The CCI on Wednesday approved the proposed amalgamation of Coursera's arm Chess Merger Sub with Udemy Inc. After the merger, Udemy will survive as a wholly-owned subsidiary of Coursera. Upon closing, existing Coursera shareholders are expected to own 59 per cent, while Udemy will own about 41 per cent of the combined company, on a fully diluted basis, the CCI said. **™**

Meta laying off hundreds of employees

Meta Platforms is laying off a few hundred people across multiple teams on Wednesday, a source familiar with the matter told Reuters. According to an earlier report in *The Information*, the cuts would affect Meta's Reality Labs division, social media teams and recruiting operations. **REUTERS**

Big-ticket RCB, RR sale set to reshape overall valuation of the IPL ecosystem

STRONG FUTURE. Deals set the stage for higher expectations from the next media rights auction cycle

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The sale of Rajasthan Royals and Royal Challengers Bengaluru at whopping price tags is set to potentially reshape the overall valuation of the Indian Premier League ecosystem. Analysts said not only does this mean an up-side in valuations commanded by other franchises but it also sets the stage for higher expectations from the next media rights auction cycle of the T20 league. Experts also pointed out that while the valuation of the IPL ecosystem will surge, the gap between it and most valued leagues such as NFL remains, given the latter's global appeal. Pointing out that this in-

dicates strong global investor interest in IPL franchises as an asset class, Santosh N, Managing Partner of D&P Advisory, said, "Gujarat Titans last year was valued at about \$1 billion and now Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Rajasthan Royals have been valued at \$1.78 billion and \$1.63 billion, respectively. I would say this is a gamechanger as it means every single IPL franchise today is worth over \$1.5 billion. This milestone has been achieved in a shorter period of time compared to other global leagues." "The investors seem to be betting on a potential increase in the number of matches in the future, which will mean higher revenues for franchises. What is also



MORE WAY TO GO. While the valuation of the overall IPL ecosystem will surge, the gap between it and most valued leagues such as NFL remains given the latter's global appeal, say experts

critical is the assumption they are making about the renewal of media rights for IPL. There is perhaps an expectation of a significant up-side in terms of renewal of the media rights cycle, con-

sidering the media rights valuations have grown from about \$2.5 billion to over \$6 billion so far," Santosh noted.

GLOBAL INVESTORS
Ajimon Francis, MD, Brand

RCB deal underscores monetisation potential of IPL teams

Sanjana B
Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

United Spirits Ltd's (USL) ₹16,660-crore sale of Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) to a consortium led by the Aditya Birla Group underscores surging Indian Premier League (IPL) franchise valuations, as investors bet on the Indian cricket industry's long-term growth driven by digital consumption, media rights, and global expansion, according to analysts and industry experts. The liquor giant, on Wednesday, entered into definitive agreements to sell its 100 per cent stake in Royal Challengers Sports Pvt Ltd (RC-SPL) to a consortium comprising Aditya Birla Group, The Times of India Group,

Bolt Ventures, and Blackstone's BXPE in an all-cash deal. RCSPL owns and operates the RCB franchises in the IPL and Women's Premier League (WPL), with ownership transferring to the consortium upon completion of the sale.

STRONG TAILWINDS
According to USL's annual report, in FY25 RCSPL reported ₹504 crore revenue from operations, a 21 per cent decrease, primarily due to fewer men's IPL matches played by RCB. Profit for the year fell to ₹140 crore from ₹222 crore in the previous fiscal, also impacted by the reduced match count. RC-SPL contributed 1.9 per cent to USL's standalone revenue from operations and net worth, which stood at ₹321 crore as of March 31, 2025.



OWNER'S PRIDE. United Spirits Ltd will sell Royal Challengers Sports Pvt Ltd to a consortium led by the Aditya Birla Group for ₹16,660 crore **REUTERS**

Despite the near-term dip, experts point to strong structural tailwinds underpinning IPL franchise valuations. "The IPL valuation surge is not just about who is investing, but how the underlying consumption story in India has evolved," said Satish Meena, Advisor at

Datum Intelligence. "With cheap data post-Jio and smartphone-led viewing, the league has moved from TV-limited reach to mass digital consumption. That has expanded both eyeballs and ad spends significantly." He added that what was once a modest revenue

model is now "a proper business", with per-match economics scaling up sharply. "Investors are betting on long-term growth, not quick flips. Over the next decade, rising fan engagement, commerce opportunities, and higher media rights will continue to drive value."

IN A GLOBAL LEAGUE
Lloyd Mathias, business strategist and independent director, said the back-to-back deals involving RCB and Rajasthan Royals underscore the IPL's emergence as a global sporting property, comparable to leagues such as the NBA and the English Premier League. He pointed to three key drivers — scarcity value, with only 10 franchises; assured revenue streams from lucrative media rights deals;

and the prestige associated with team ownership, alongside high-profile global investors. Under the current media rights cycle (2023–27), valued at over ₹48,000 crore, franchises receive a steady annual payout, creating predictable cash flows. Alongside this, IPL franchises are expanding beyond India, aided by the growth of women's cricket and global interest, further strengthening long-term value creation. "The PE firms are mostly seeking an increased valuation 5-6 years from now. On the other hand, for a large diversified group like Aditya Birla, the advantage is that they can use it to promote any one of their various companies. And for Diageo, it's a great exit. It's a win-win for everybody involved," he said.

Flights at Navi Mumbai airport to grow 3x in summer schedule

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Flights at Navi Mumbai airport are set to treble with the launch of new destinations, including Kolkata, Ayodhya, Agra and Tirupati, in the summer schedule starting Sunday.

Domestic passenger operations at Navi Mumbai began last Christmas with 46 scheduled flights (arrival and departure). The airport currently handles around the same number of scheduled flights and this is expected to increase to 144 in the summer schedule. There are no immediate plans for international operations.

CAPACITY EXPANSION
Until February end, the airport handled over 4 lakh pas-



Until February end, the airport handled over 4 lakh passengers

sengers, Airport Authority of India data show. IndiGo will lead the capacity expansion at the airport with 116 flights (arrival and departures). The number of destinations connected by IndiGo from Navi Mumbai will rise

from 13 to 46. This follows a tweak in its network. Destinations like Ayodhya, Agra, Hindon, Jabalpur and Tirupati will be served from Navi Mumbai instead of Mumbai. An executive said there would be no reduction in overall capacity at Mumbai and only destinations contributing fewer connecting traffic to its international routes are being moved to Navi Mumbai. Akasa Air is expected to operate 16 flights and add new destinations — Kolkata and Lucknow. Air India Express will have around 12 flights daily, including a new service to Hyderabad. Star Air, which launched operations from Navi Mumbai on Day 1, is not resuming connectivity from the airport. The airline earlier cited aircraft availability issues for the route suspension.

Civil society warns of 'WTO reform capture'

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Civil society organisations across countries have warned that the "reform" push from developed countries at the WTO's 14th Ministerial Conference (MC14), which opens today in Yaounde, Cameroon, risks eroding the institution's development mandate. "Today, some of the key developed country members led by the US and the EU are attempting to hijack the stated objective of 'reforming the WTO' to push through a complete remake of the organisation into what promises to be an even more dangerous construct," said a joint statement from 51 civil society organisations from various countries, coordinated by the Our World Is Not For Sale (OWINFS). The coalition warned that the proposals under discus-



COURSE CORRECTION. Calls are growing for thwarting attempts to dilute the development mandate and shrink policy space for poorer nations **REUTERS**

sion could dilute core principles such as non-discrimination, legitimise unilateral trade deals concluded under tariff pressure, and institutionalise decision-making through exclusive plurilateral arrangements dominated by major economies.

PRIME TARGET
"What is unfolding at MC14 is not reform — it is capture. We are witnessing the US and the EU using the lan-

guage of 'relevance' to systematically strip developing countries of the policy space and flexibilities they have negotiated and bargained for. This process risks normalising coercion as a negotiating tool, while shifting agenda-setting power even further toward the interests of the world's most powerful countries and largest corporations," said Jane Nalunga, Executive Director of SEAT-INI, a think tank covering

southern and eastern African trade issues. Although competition from China is cited as the prime target of the United States and the European Union, it is actually the poorer WTO members who will suffer most, the statement noted. "Through plurilateral agreements (including part of the membership not full), and the sidelining of developing countries' own agendas, the WTO will become the platform for new rules (for example, on State support and on State-Owned Enterprises) that will further constrain any pathways that developing countries might have in order to achieve long-term sustainable development and structural transformation or any kind of competitive edge," the statement added. Another concern is the push by developed countries to make permanent the

moratorium on customs duties on electronic transmissions. Civil society groups said allowing the moratorium to lapse would restore much-needed fiscal space for developing countries. While rejecting the current reform direction, the coalition emphasised it is not defending the status quo. It called for strengthening special and differential treatment provisions, securing a permanent solution on public stockholding for food security, revisiting intellectual property rules to improve access to medicines and climate technologies, and restoring policy autonomy. "The question is not whether the WTO needs to change — it clearly does. The question is whether the proposed changes address its failures or entrench them. On that test, they do not pass," said Chee Yoke Ling, Executive Director of Third World Network.

Kiran Mani of JioStar to join OpenAI as APAC Managing Director in June

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Kiran Mani, CEO of JioStar, will join OpenAI as Managing Director for the Asia-Pacific region from June 2026, according to industry sources. At OpenAI, Mani will lead APAC regional strategy and operations and report to Jason Kwon, OpenAI's Chief Strategy Officer. Currently based in India, Mani will move to Singapore for the new role. Mani's appointment comes at a time when OpenAI has been looking to expand its international presence. India ranks as its second largest market globally by weekly users, and Japan and Indonesia are also in the top 10. The company reported significant enterprise



Kiran Mani, Founder-CEO of JioHotStar

adoption, with Japan as the top market outside the US for business users of ChatGPT, while three of the top five markets globally for Co-dex are in APAC, including India, as per sources.

NEW OFFICES
Since April 2025, OpenAI has set up offices in Tokyo, Singapore, Australia, Korea, and India. The sources said

that OpenAI is working with organisations in APAC to deploy AI tools across workforces and integrate advanced models into products and services at scale. Mani will continue to serve as CEO at JioStar until June, leading its digital platforms across sports and entertainment, as per an internal note to employees. According to Mani's LinkedIn profile, he had also led the merger of Viacom18 with Star India Pvt Ltd to launch the platform JioHotstar. Prior to JioStar, Mani was Managing Director for Android and Google Play in APAC, besides stints at Microsoft and IBM. Mani is a national merit scholar from the Institute of Chartered Financial Analysts and has a PGDBA from IBS Hyderabad.

No coercive action without hearing Meta: Delhi HC

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday asked the Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) not to take any coercive action against Meta Platforms Inc over an unauthorised listing on Facebook marketplace without giving the US-based social media giant an opportunity to present its stand. Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav, while dealing with Meta's petition against a CCPA order imposing a ₹10 lakh penalty on it for alleged unauthorised sale and listing of walkie-talkies on the Facebook Marketplace, said the platform cannot be penalised by giving "vague and omnibus" directions. The senior counsel for Meta said that in compliance with the order, the platform

was not permitting any listings for walkie-talkies on the marketplace but objected to the other "omnibus" directions to it, including ensuring that no other product requiring statutory approval/certification was listed or sold without due approvals.

LEGALLY EMPOWERED
The counsel for the Centre defended the order and submitted that the CCPA was legally empowered to pass the directions. "The court, however, finds that the petitioner could not be penalised on account of any vague or omnibus directions which seem to have been issued in paragraph 43(b) (of the order). Unless the act of the petitioner is clearly in violation of any applicable rules or regulations, the petitioner cannot be penalised," said Justice Purushendra Kaurav.

Sunil Mittal to retire as Chairman of Airtel Africa Board after AGM in July

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Airtel Africa on Wednesday said Sunil Bharti Mittal will retire from the post of Board Chair after the annual general meeting (AGM) in July. Gopal Vittal will be appointed Non-Executive Chair of the Board. Mittal, who has been Chair since the company's listing in 2019, has informed the Board of his intention to retire, according to a statement. Shrawin Bharti Mittal will assume the role of Deputy Chair and ensure continuity with the founding family and significant shareholder, it added. He will be the Board's conduit with the Airtel Money Board, on which he serves, and with Airtel Africa's headquarters in Dubai, where he is based, it said.



Airtel Africa has a solid strategy and an outstanding leadership team in place... so I am confident that now is time for me to step aside as Chair

SUNIL BHARTI MITTAL
Board Chair, Airtel Africa

'OUTSTANDING TEAM'
"Airtel Africa has a solid

strategy and an outstanding leadership team in place, the strength of which is evident in recent results, so I am confident that now is the time for me to step aside as Chair..." Sunil Mittal said. "I know the company will continue to prosper and to advance the transformative power of connectivity to the millions of customers we serve across 14 African countries," he said. As part of the ongoing succession planning, Non-Executive Director Annika Poutiainen will also retire after the July AGM, Airtel Africa said. It said Vittal's appointment is by nomination of the controlling shareholder pursuant to the terms of the relationship agreement dated June 17, 2019. He was appointed Non-Executive Director of Airtel Africa in October 2024.



the spokesperson said.

E-COMMERCE TAX
On the moratorium on customs duties on e-commerce, the statement said, "India has highlighted the rapidly evolving nature of the digital economy, particularly in the context of emerging technologies, and the need for policy space to enable countries to effectively harness these developments," the statement noted. The US and other countries have made a case for a permanent moratorium on customs duties on e-commerce, instead of extending it by two years at a time. Critics say this would take away from developing countries the policy option of taxing it in the future and lead to huge loss of potential revenues as the world moves from physical goods to digital ones.

The Indian delegation is led by Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal, and includes officials from the Department of Commerce, officers from the Permanent Mission of India in Geneva, representatives from other stakeholder ministries/departments, as well as technical and legal experts participating in various negotiating tracks.

"In the run-up to MC14, India has consistently underlined the need for an open, fair, inclusive, and non-discriminatory multilateral trading system, with the WTO at its core," the statement highlighted.

WTO MC14: India to prioritise food security, development concerns

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India will push for food security and livelihood protection at the 14th WTO Ministerial Conference (MC14) on March 26-29 in Yaounde, Cameroon, prioritising a permanent solution on public stockholding and stronger special treatment for developing nations to uphold the multilateral mandate, the government has said.

"The country will emphasise the importance of respecting the multilateral mandate of the WTO, prioritising food security, safeguarding the livelihoods of small farmers and fishers, and ensuring adequate policy space for developing economies, particularly in emerging areas such as digital trade," says a statement issued by the Commerce Department on Wednesday.

India's emphasis on respecting the multilateral mandate is important amid attempts by some members, led mostly by developed countries, to push plurilateral deals and reinterpret core principles under the reform agenda. New Delhi fears this could dilute consensus-based decision-making and sideline development priorities.

CHINA-LED IFD
On the China-led Investment Facilitation for Development (IFD) agreement, the statement noted that India supported initiatives that facilitate investment flows into developing countries, including least developed countries (LDCs).

However, a spokesperson clarified that there has been no change in India's opposition to the IFD proposal at the WTO.

"India feels that WTO, being a trade body, is not the appropriate forum for this,"

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Company	Prev	Close	Open	High	Low	Qty	52WH	52WL	PE	BSE CI
Omax Autos	92.77	97.69	93.56	100.00	93.56	4611	16528	78.00	10	98.40
OMNITECH ENG	235.94	233.59	238.60	246.00	238.60	4289	5250	176.25	-	-
Omni Petrochem	44.27	44.91	44.91	45.10	44.91	1618	1618	12.50	15.00	126.30
OmniMobility	175.08	177.11	176.70	181.50	175.12	644.58	337.00	171.31	-	-
OncorSecurSpe	116.10	134.10	110.00	143.40	112.00	132.50	224.00	107.00	-	-
ORACLE	275.00	282.00	280.00	288.00	275.00	108.00	632.00	10	27.25	-
OMNIBOLE	46.03	45.59	46.30	47.47	45.25	285.89	75.00	40.00	12	45.55
Onward Techn	231.20	239.25	231.20	254.70	231.20	428.00	206.80	17	23.80	-
OPTITEMUS	328.65	331.75	331.00	341.00	328.65	173.86	71.25	105.55	17	330.85
ORACLE [5]	275.00	282.00	280.00	288.00	275.00	108.00	632.00	10	27.25	-
Orchid Ph	51.15	53.165	51.52	55.05	51.52	119.50	89.00	48.00	-	-
ORIENT CEM [1]	128.75	131.65	129.75	133.75	129.39	47.24	36.25	123.00	8	131.50
Orient Infra	31.65	36.92	32.71	39.09	36.75	54.73	56.64	36.75	-	-
Orient Elec	162.17	159.99	162.96	164.90	157.99	22.77	24.80	153.35	-	-
Orient Hotel [1]	91.03	92.11	91.03	94.33	91.03	22.98	16.00	80.50	28	92.15
Orient Petro	235.25	282.00	280.00	288.00	235.25	108.00	632.00	10	27.25	-
OrientLaroma	235.25	282.00	280.00	288.00	235.25	108.00	632.00	10	27.25	-
Orissa Min	339.00	348.50	340.00	356.00	342.00	18.13	613.00	3281.00	-	3486.45
Orissa India	59.40	59.45	59.00	59.50	58.50	129.50	76.00	53.25	-	-
OswalPumps	307.50	313.75	308.00	321.50	308.00	829.88	88.40	283.10	-	-

Company	Prev	Close	Open	High	Low	Qty	52WH	52WL	PE	BSE CI
P&G Healthc	403.76	416.71	416.00	429.00	416.00	497.00	473.00	40.00	-	-
Pace Digitel	155.36	156.43	157.25	161.00	155.16	598.56	23.51	153.01	-	-
Page Ind	3217.00	3263.00	3235.00	3340.00	3218.00	30.73	2047.00	2980.00	-	4236.82.05
Pakka	87.42	88.57	90.49	96.00	87.42	59.88	39.94	72.78	74.12	-
Panasonic Bio [1]	110.00	112.08	111.05	113.89	109.11	7586.30	23.39	95.97	-	-
Paradeep Phos	119.05	120.61	119.98	120.75	119.50	85.11	37.20	142.10	16	201.40
Park Petrol	622.95	622.95	640.00	640.00	622.95	94.50	38.05	-	-	-
Park Hotels	104.81	105.00	105.00	109.00	105.00	63.55	16.73	120.11	-	-
Park MediWo	205.36	200.21	208.70	208.70	200.00	837.09	208.72	138.10	-	-
Passputi Agr	43.37	44.13	44.79	45.05	44.51	161.53	63.50	40.10	-	-
Patel Infra	47.20	45.80	47.88	49.05	47.00	141.12	201.10	46.41	-	-
Patel engg [1]	24.08	24.75	24.10	25.35	24.10	89.40	46.59	23.33	6	24.74
Patel Retail	163.12	163.36	164.50	172.00	162.85	164.52	305.00	155.00	-	-
PATCO	120.10	106.50	106.50	107.00	106.50	24.15	42.93	27.00	-	-
PF Fintech	146.10	146.80	148.00	151.60	146.10	203.80	197.00	136.40	-	-
PC Jeweller [1]	8.00	8.12	8.15	8.34	8.00	42.09	196.5	7.74	-	8.11
PDS	269.70	269.70	269.70	269.70	269.70	269.70	269.70	269.70	-	-
PDS	274.05	281.65	275.10	287.05	276.60	183.67	46.60	246.05	-	-
Penland Ltd [2]	16.51	16.27	16.53	16.76	16.46	78.14	4.60	14.55	-	16.30
PENMAR IND [5]	142.51	142.54	143.29	147.61	141.41	1047.39	279.80	133.00	-	142.35
Petrochem	47.20	49.80	49.80	49.80	47.20	49.80	49.80	49.80	-	-
Petroleum LNG	24.91	24.98	24.95	26.25	24.54	55.25	871.11	32.50	10	24.95
Pfizer Ltd	465.90	470.95	467.40	476.00	467.50	10.49	598.75	63.40	27.80	470.15
PGL	14.00	14.72	14.50	15.00	14.50	14.72	14.50	14.72	-	-
PGL [5]	14.00	14.72	14.50	15.00	14.50	14.72	14.50	14.72	-	-
Phoenix Mill [1]	150.53	157.20	153.00	158.00	151.50	69.21	17.95	100.00	142	156.95
PhysicWall	87.72	86.05	88.70	89.75	85.50	82.18	54.16	16.99	77.72	-
PIC INDIA [5]	275.00	282.00	280.00	288.00	275.00	108.00	632.00	10	27.25	2905.45
Piccadilly Agr	54.20	54.15	54.50	55.40	53.90	8.50	92.50	80.50	51.00	-
Pidilite [1]	133.20	136.20	135.20	138.90	135.00	88.96	157.50	129.80	80	136.30.05
Pine Ind	16.40	16.40	16.40	16.40	16.40	16.40	16.40	16.40	-	-
Piramal Fin	180.80	181.30	180.80	182.10	178.00	37.28	154.50	126.00	-	-
Piramal Phos	136.08	141.07	136.08	145.00	135.76	425.88	11.90	23.20	132.00	-
Pital Engg [5]	75.95	75.20	76.38	77.90	74.70	111.21	112.00	67.20	27	75.55
Prestige Ind	208.00	207.47	208.00	214.50	208.00	214.50	208.00	214.50	-	-
Plaza Viries	31.65	32.02	31.50	32.94	31.51	65.64	65.34	31.00	-	-
PN Gadgil Jw	56.05	56.50	56.50	57.60	55.95	16.82	70.10	47.80	-	-
PN Infra	46.82	46.82	46.82	46.82	46.82	46.82	46.82	46.82	-	65.91
PNB Housing	78.25	80.28	78.90	81.20	78.65	162.66	131.85	73.00	9	80.375
PNF Ind	17.32	17.89	17.18	18.39	17.48	75.32	31.80	17.00	13	17.840
PNV Infra	36.15	36.50	36.30	36.15	36.15	36.15	36.15	36.15	-	-
Pokarna Ltd [2]	78.78	82.00	82.00	82.00	78.78	82.00	82.00	82.00	-	-
Poly Medico	124.40	130.62	124.90	136.70	124.50	39.61	239.60	119.65	63	130.720
Poly Ind	706.40	714.50	712.00	727.00	710.04	49.52	872.00	456.00	-	-
Polysar	82.00	80.90	83.80	84.35	80.90	163.94	196.80	77.50	-	81.90
PonwallaFin	38.15	39.06	38.25	39.60	38.15	74.30	57.00	31.80	-	-
Pondy Ondes	106.20	110.90	109.00	113.20	107.20	256.23	157.80	51.40	-	-
Pony Ind	75.75	76.25	76.50	77.10	76.25	77.10	76.25	77.10	-	26.890
Posi Corp	85.67	85.67	85.67	85.67	85.67	85.67	85.67	85.67	-	-
Power Fin	39.85	40.35	40.15	40.90	40.05	93.29	61.45	33.05	7	40.35
Power grid	29.90	29.50	29.90	30.25	29.50	29.50	29.50	29.50	-	29.50
Power Infra	10.75	10.75	10.75	10.75	10.75	10.75	10.75	10.75	-	-
Power Mech	161.43	162.34	163.00	165.24	161.98	96.34	20.90	14.60	12	162.30
POWERTECH	187.90	191.80	189.00	195.70	189.00	110.31	345.15	184.00	-	-
Power Infra	141.41	145.40	143.40	149.42	143.40	13.78	17.90	120.55	-	-
Pradj Indt [2]	31.62	32.75	31.50	33.20	31.40	34.39	61.90	27.30	38	32.85
Prakash Ind	116.44	121.73	117.00	127.35	117.00	120.47	1.90	11.00	7	121.55
Prakash Pipe	186.22	190.03	185.89	197.50	185.03	7.81	47.30	18.26	-	-
Prakash Infra	117.30	119.26	117.30	123.80	117.30	123.80	117.30	123.80	-	-
Precision Wr [1]	36.25	34.70	33.12	33.95	33.07	99.21	35.90	118.35	44	319.45
Premier Enr	89.35	91.96	91.50	92.75	89.15	45.45	247.72	116.30	60	91.96
Prestige Exp [2]	120.10	122.80	121.50	125.00	121.50	73.41	181.10	104.80	35	122.75
Price Ind	51.30	54.35	53.60	55.50	53.10	29.89	69.95	38.15	42	54.30
Prime Foods [1]	30.80	32.05	31.25	32.55	31.00	376.10	32.02	34.00	-	-
Prime Pipe	28.10	28.10	28.10	28.10	28.10	28.10	28.10	28.10	-	-
Prism Cement	125.15	125.04	125.50	127.20	125.00	112.62	17.12	105.10	-	125.00
Priv Specit	94.00	296.30	297.00	303.90	296.00	10.78	344.00	510.00	-	-
Prochem Ind	94.00	96.50	96.00	97.00	95.50	15.15	164.30	69.35	36	96.43.35
Protean Ind	12.48	12.29	12.90	13.37	12.28	39.84	25.49	10.00	-	-
Prostam Ego	49.55	49.76	50.20	51.30	49.40	51.30	48.54	49.00	-	-
Prostam Rhy	49.55	49.76	50.20	51.30	49.40	51.30	48.54	49.00	-	-
Prostam Corp	23.20	23.25	23.20	23.52	23.20	47.02	102.00	175.00	-	-
PSPPROJECT	63.10	63.70	62.30	65.00	62.30	60.40	103.80	57.70	70	63.80
PTC Ind	165.83	164.30	163.62	167.00	163.62	24.43	193.00	119.00	-	-
PUNJAB SER	70.01	71.80	71.50	74.28	71.00	27.72	14.85	63.11	7	72.52
PUNJCHEM	1018.70	1029.00	1028.40	1030.00	1028.00	10.31	1664.95	789.00	20	1011.90
PUNJ Indt [2]	22.13	22.76	22.13	23.06	22.13	22.76	24.90	21.26	13	22.88
PUNJABINSID	174.10	181.69	175.11	187.50	175.11	65.19	33.80	160.00	-	181.40
Puravankara [5]	97.24	95.40	94.50	96.90	95.00	41.26	124.70	83.00	-	-

Company	Prev	Close	Open	High	Low	Qty	52WH	52WL	PE	BSE CI
Quadrant Fut	290.75	291.25	287.10	301.90	287.10	253.81	604.75	248.55	-	-
Quadrant Fut	840.00	854.45	845.00	881.85	836.65	1631.60	1082.00	267.80	-	-
Quality Power	175.08	176.17	175.01	179.00	175.01	179.00	175.01	179.00	-	176.45
QuickCoal	141.67	141.64	141.48	146.15	141.00	21.33	41.60	135.00	113	141.40

Company	Prev	Close	Open	High	Low	Qty	52WH	52WL	PE	BSE CI
RACL Genco	57.01	57.15	57.50	59.40	56.30	23.93	11.50	54.90	-	-
Radiant Cms	34.90	35.56	35.00	36.80	35.00	36.97	73.80	33.95	-	-
RadiantKhat [2]	263.70	274.00	265.70	276.00	263.70	49.58	108.00	232.00	-	267.947.90